Final Report - Strengthening the regional innovation ecosystem through internal and international collaboration – Towards a roadmap for action

Smart Specialisation Community of Practice (S3 CoP)

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Executive Summary

Objectives

This report presents the outcomes of a targeted support assignment provided to the S3 regional authorities in Aragon under the S3 Community of Practice, aimed at strengthening the regional innovation ecosystem in Aragón.

The assignment focused on assessing the current state of Aragón's regional innovation ecosystems in water, security and defence, digitalisation and artificial intelligence, and coordination within the regional government. The results contributed to outlining actions and a roadmap for the regional authorities to strengthen both the internal and international connections of Aragón's innovation system.

Challenges Addressed

Recent analysis promoted by Regional Government of Aragón reveals that while some key actors are well-connected internationally through interregional innovation projects, most regional actors do not participate in these opportunities.[1] Additionally, the regional government has also presence in most well-known European networks but do not fully leverage the potential of being member that could result in the promotion of strategic innovation projects in regional S3 priorities.

Participating in international innovation projects first requires a strong and well-connected regional ecosystem—one that makes full use of all available local capacities and opportunities. It is therefore essential to assess the current state of collaboration among innovation stakeholders in the region. This will help identify existing strengths and weaknesses, determine what is already available locally, and clarify what is needed from external partners. Such an assessment is critical to successfully tapping into European and international innovation opportunities.

Main Results

The assessment revealed common gaps in the three regional ecosystems and in the overall approach of the regional government departments that support innovation, notably highlighting a fragmented approach to ecosystem coordination, limited international engagement, and underdeveloped support instruments.

The water ecosystem, while more mature than the others, continues to face limited critical mass and engagement from industry sectors other that traditional water management industry. These sectors has yet to fully recognise and invest in its potential as a cross-cutting strategic area. Likewise, the regional government is not providing enough with a vision and detailed plans for water management and climate change in the region.

The security and defence ecosystem is at a unique turning point, with stakeholders showing unprecedented determination to organise, collaborate, and launch strategic

[1] DGPII has supported the study by CIRCE: *Análisis del Sistema aragonés de I+D+I basado en redes*, which is not published yey

projects. These efforts build on Aragon's long military tradition and regional technological and industrial strengths, particularly in the security and defence sector and dual-use development opportunities for regional industries. **Recent national and European momentum in defence policy, especially around dual-use technologies, offers Aragón a valuable opportunity to reactivate and reposition this sector within its broader industrial ecosystem included in the S3 Aragón 2021-2027 strategy.**

This emergent ecosystem, however, faces specific challenges, notably the fragmentation of its innovation ecosystem and the need of better position both at national and European level, where leadership and collaboration structures are still in development.

In parallel, the digital ecosystem, particularly in AI, is missing key opportunities: first, leveraging the public sector as a powerful driver of demand by better mapping needs, improving internal coordination, and clearly communicating challenges to the ecosystem; second, capitalizing on the arrival of major foreign investments in data centres, which could spark demand for advanced services from Aragón's most innovative SMEs. However, skill gaps within the administration and the absence of a comprehensive, action-backed strategy are holding back the full exploitation of this potential.

The Regional Government of Aragon recognizes the importance of international engagement but faces key challenges: low participation in EU projects due to budget, administrative, and language barriers; limited early access to information on calls; and weak internal coordination and knowledge-sharing. Opportunities lie in strengthening strategic governance, improving coordination, and clearly defining Aragón's positioning. Enhanced digital collaboration tools, targeted company outreach, capacity building, and better financial support mechanisms can boost both public and business engagement in internationalisation, helping Aragón unlock its full potential in European and global innovation ecosystems.

These findings form the basis for the roadmap of the Innovation Office to support regional and European collaboration as a way through improving regional ecosystems competitiveness.

Based on the above, the work carried out by the Directorate-General for Industrial Promotion and Innovation (DGPII in Spanish) to stimulate the regional ecosystem is noteworthy, particularly its role in creating spaces for collaboration, enabling knowledge exchange, and providing targeted technical support where needed. With the recent Innovation Office, it is timely and welcome that it integrates the following operational recommendations into its initial work plan to further develop and strengthen Aragón's innovation ecosystem.

Recommendations

Actionable recommendations for the Innovation Office:

- **Become the one stop shop for ecosystem coordination & visibility**: Maintain and expand Innohub sessions, support emerging innovation hubs, and organise flagship annual ecosystem events. Integrate the coordination efforts under the S3 governance.
- **Enhancing intelligence for innovation and regional and international collaboration**: Develop an updated innovation ecosystem map, a repository of projects and actors, and publish an annual innovation report. The S3 Monitoring system could be updated and contribute for these purposes.
- **Conduct a structured assessment of current regional policy instruments and grants that support innovation**: Establish a funding intelligence and matchmaking service; assess and adapt current support instruments; test new soft instruments like innovation agents.
- **Integration into regional and EU collaboration**: Monitor participation in EU networks and support structured internationalisation strategies for stakeholders.
- **Capacity Building**: Provide cross-learning opportunities for example sharing good practices from experienced partners, training in preparation of EU proposals, internal training for ecosystem facilitation, and support the transition of working groups into autonomous platforms.

By implementing these recommendations, the Innovation Office will position itself as an essential actor in Aragón's innovation governance, capable of catalysing collaboration, improving coordination, and amplifying the region's presence on the European innovation stage.

1.Introduction

The Government of Aragón, led by the Directorate-General for Industrial Promotion and Innovation (DGPII), is undertaking various actions to identify and implement a roadmap of initiatives to position the territory as an innovative region at international level. Focused on business competitiveness and industrial promotion, this Directorate is the body responsible for managing the S3 Aragón 2021-2027 and operates independently from departments overseeing research and universities, with a specific emphasis on fostering business-led innovation.

Recent analysis promoted by DGII of the Aragón's innovation system reveals that while some key actors are well-connected internationally through interregional innovation projects, most regional actors do not participate in these opportunities.[2] Additionally, the regional government has also presence in most well-known European networks but do not fully leverage the potential of being member that could result in the promotion of strategic innovation projects in regional S3 priorities.

Participating in international innovation projects first requires a strong and well-connected regional ecosystem—one that makes full use of all available local capacities and opportunities. It is therefore essential to assess the current state of collaboration among innovation stakeholders in the region. This will help identify existing strengths and weaknesses, determine what is already available locally, and clarify what is needed from external partners. Such an assessment is critical to successfully tapping into European and international innovation opportunities.

To address these interrelated challenges, this Targeted Assignment has set the following objectives:

Assessment of the current situation in the innovation ecosystem in Aragón, including the analysis of good practices from other regions

A description of actions and tools to strengthen both the internal and international connections of Aragón's innovation system.

This report provides the process and results of this assignment, and it is structured as follows developed through stakeholder co-design activities and structured around four core sections: (1) a diagnosis of challenges (Section 5), (2) actionable recommendations for the forthcoming Innovation Office (Section 6) and (3) the critical role of political commitment (Section 7).:

- Section 2 presents the introduction
- Section 3 summarizes the overarching methodology
- Section 4 provides a summary of the policy mapping exercise related to actors and networks

[2] DGPII has supported the study by CIRCE: *Análisis del Sistema aragonés de I+D+I basado en redes*, which is not published yey

- Section 5, building on the fieldwork (interviews, focus groups and presential workshops), identifies the challenges that the regional system faces, in improving the reginal connections and the position and International and EU level, within the S3 framework
- Section 6 proposes a set of Actionable recommendations and a roadmap for the Innovation Office
- Section 7 outlines the next steps for active engagement from the regional government

This targeted assignment has been designed with a participatory approach at its core. The primary focus has been to engage local stakeholders directly. By building on document review, open dataset analysis, and interviews, it has possible to develop a good understanding of their needs and perspectives. This groundwork led to participatory workshops where stakeholders had the opportunity to co-create and take ownership of a priority actions to improve coordination at regional level, promote innovation projects in collaboration and improve positioning in EU arena. These actions will serve mainly as a foundation for future actions by the Innovation Office but also as repository of actions to be implemented but other stakeholders engaged in promoting collaboration and innovation projects in the region. The exercise provided valuable insights into stakeholders' appetite and commitment to collaboration and innovation, revealing a policy gap.

2.Methodology

The methodology for the targeted assignment in Aragón includes several elements organized into three main phases: Preparatory Steps, Fieldwork, and Output. Together they allow to develop a set of actions for strengthening the internal and external linkages in the region, framed within the Smart Specialisation Strategy, grounded in the local policy context and in the needs of local stakeholders.

Preparatory steps:

- **Policy mapping**: This involved analysing the current state of the region by examining key policies at the regional, national, and EU levels that impact Aragón, with a focus on S3.
- **Local stakeholder mapping** (in cooperation with the regional services): This involved identifying and mobilizing key stakeholders, including public sector representatives, universities, research and technology organizations (RTOs), clusters, and businesses. This was done in close collaboration with the regional services, identifying projects and stakeholders of relevance to the assignment.
- Here it is worth to mention the study carried out by Circe where is assessing the capacity of networking of regional stakeholders through research and innovation projects specially in EU framework programmes. Despite the study is not published yet, first insights were shared, and it was important to identify most active entities

that could help in the knowledge and innovation spillovers and the different maturity levels of the several ecosystems in the region in terms of trajectory and number of projects. The ecosystems of the study (water, security and defence and digital and AI in the public sector) were identified among the less mature and hence more work is needed to strengthen the links between entities to foster collaboration and innovative projects.

- **Identification of key actors in EU regions with similar strategic objectives and priorities:** as part of the preparatory steps, and as a legacy of the targeted assignment, a relation of detailed good practices were identified for the region to engage in future internationalisation activities, see
- Annex I – Identification of other regions with similar strategic objectives and good practices, These practices aim to facilitate the development of partnerships for innovation projects and foster knowledge and technology sharing to promote innovation.
- The identified good practices were classified into three categories and various platforms and datasets were used to identify the stakeholders. These categories include:
  - Identification of EU regions with similar S3 priorities to Aragón, some of which demonstrate stronger economic performance (e.g. higher GDP per capita) or more advanced innovation capacity (as indicated by the Regional Innovation Scoreboard) but represented good practices in terms of regional collaboration. These regions could serve as reference points or potential partners for future collaboration.
  - Regional cases in detail including a descriptive fiche of a selected group of regions, outlining main characteristics, strengths, and networks that support innovation and collaboration with an assessment their potential relevance to Aragón's strategic objectives
  - Networks and events: Identification of thematic networks, initiatives, and events of interest

The objective is to provide the DGPII a reference document with contacts of regions with similar interests and projects that helps to better position Aragón as innovative region in the EU.

Fieldwork

- **Focus Groups:** We conducted four focus groups at the end of November, targeting the four ecosystems under study: water, security and defence, digital technologies and AI in the public sector (as a transversal case). These sessions aimed to gather detailed insights into regional challenges and opportunities at regional and European level. The DGPII played a central role in mobilising stakeholders.

  Each focus group included broad representation from across the ecosystem-companies, research institutes, technology centres, and the public sector-and was structured around four key topics:
  - Regional cooperation in Aragón: characteristics of participation, challenges, and opportunities

  - International/European collaboration: characteristics of participation, challenges, and opportunities
  - Expectations from the public sector
  - Ecosystem capacity-building needs

- **Presential Workshops**: Building in the outcomes of the focus group, we organised workshops to engage stakeholders in participatory exercises aimed at identifying shared objectives, needs, skills gaps, and opportunities for collaboration. Together with the regional services, we organized:
  - A workshop with the public sector representatives, held on 17 February. The
  - A workshop with local stakeholders from the Defence and Security Sector on 17 February
  - A workshop with local stakeholders from Water Sector on 18 February
  - A workshop with local stakeholders from the Digital Technology Sector on 18 February

Each session was well attended and built upon a pre-prepared SWOT analysis based on focus group results. This SWOT was validated and enriched during the workshops. As a final step, participants proposed and prioritised a list of concrete short- and medium-term actions for their respective ecosystems.

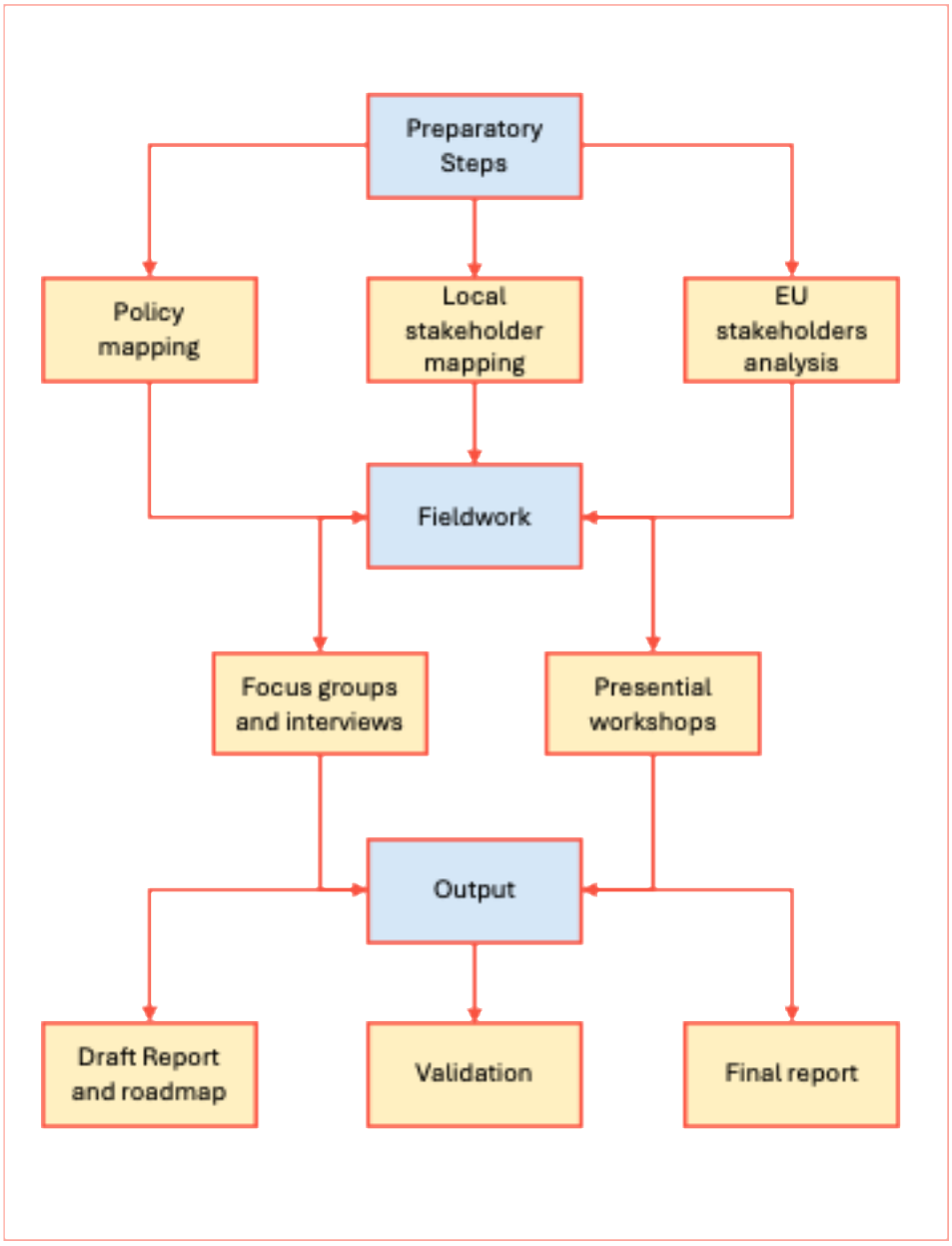
Online discussion on political commitment:

Building on the roadmap, the last step of the process, included reflection and discussion with representatives from the regional administration, regional political actors, the Spanish Geographical Unit of DG REGIO, and the expert. The discussion centred on identifying politically endorsed actions and commitments, in line with the initiatives and the identified actions plan developed with stakeholders.

Output:

- **Draft Report and Roadmap:** A draft report, outlining the findings from the mapping exercises, interviews, and workshops, and proposal of actionable recommendations for regional development was developed.
- **Validation:** The draft was presented, via email and in a dedicated meeting, to regional stakeholders and DG REGIO, ensuring the recommendations are feasible and aligned with regional priorities and EC expectations.
- **Final Report:** The draft report was integrated with feedback from the validation process, with particular attention on the role of political commitments.

Figure 1: Methodological Framework



The preparatory documents, including guidelines for focus groups and workshops, as well as the results, such as PowerPoint presentations with stakeholder contributions, SWOT analyses, or questionnaire outcomes, are transferred to the DGPII in Aragon and are available upon request.

3. Policy and networks mapping and assessment of the regional innovation ecosystem

a. Economic profile of Aragón

Aragón, located in the northeast of Spain, is home to approximately 1.33 million inhabitants, representing around 2.8% of the national population. Covering an area of nearly 48,000 km², it is one of the most sparsely populated regions in Spain, with a population density well below the national average.

The region has a diversified economy with a strong presence of manufacturing, logistics, and agri-food sectors. Aragón is a leading hub for the automotive industry and hosts several major industrial parks, particularly around Zaragoza, its capital and largest city. While small and medium-sized enterprises dominate the business landscape, large multinational firms are also active, especially in transport, energy, and machinery.

In 2024, Aragón's GDP is expected to grow by nearly 3%, a figure almost four times higher than that of the euro area (0.8%), though slightly below the national Spanish average (3.2%). This growth is driven by strong domestic demand, public investment, and a rebound in tourism, which together help offset the decline in exports—particularly in the automotive sector. The regional economy is forecast to maintain positive momentum, with projected growth of 2.2% in 2025 and 1.8% in 2026.

Aragón is increasingly positioning itself as a strategic location for energy production and digital infrastructure. The region stands out for its significant investments in renewable energy, particularly wind and solar. Recent announcements also highlight major international investments in hyperscale data centres and automotive industry, leveraging Aragón's competitive advantages in energy availability, land, local business friendly regulation and connectivity. However, this is creating regional controversy regarding the expected intensive use of natural resources like water and energy.

In the 2023 Regional Innovation Scoreboard, Aragón is classified as a moderate innovator, with a 7.4% improvement in performance since 2016. The region scores 93.7 relative to Spain and 83.6 relative to the EU. Strengths include digital skills, while weaknesses remain in ICT specialist employment. Structural challenges include low GDP per capita growth and high employment in agriculture and mining.

b. Smart Specialisation Strategy of Aragón

The Smart Specialisation Strategy of Aragón 2021–2027 builds on the lessons learned from the 2014–2020 period,[3] aiming to better align regional innovation efforts with economic transformation.

The strategy focuses on four specific objectives to address the region's identified challenges. These revolve around strengthening the link between science, technology, and business; improving coordination and funding across the innovation ecosystem with an international view; and attracting talent and entrepreneurship to modernise industry. The four Specific Objectives (SO) of the strategy are:

- **SO 1: Guide and boost Aragón's industrial transition.** Supporting the modernisation and digitalisation of the regional industrial base, with a focus on sustainability, resilience, and competitiveness.
- **SO 2: Strengthen Aragón's R&D&I system** to meet the recovery and transformation needs of the productive fabric. Enhancing research and innovation capacity to respond to the needs of local industries and societal challenges.
- **SO 3: Position and promote Aragón's knowledge and technology in regional, national, and international markets.** Fostering the internationalisation and visibility of Aragón's innovation and technological capabilities.
- **SO 4: Create, attract and retain talent in Aragón.** Building a strong talent pipeline through education, mobility, and incentives for skilled professionals and entrepreneurs.

A key focus is placed on fostering a sustainable and resilient economy by leveraging Aragón's strengths in advanced manufacturing, agri-food, health and wellbeing, renewable energy, and logistics. The strategy promotes the integration of advanced digital technologies—such as artificial intelligence, robotics, data analytics, and cybersecurity—across sectors, while strengthening collaboration within the innovation ecosystem, supporting high value-added services, and boosting internationalisation.

Building on this, the S3 Aragón 2021–2027 defines six priority areas:

- Sustainable Mobility
- Agri-Food
- Energy and Green Fuels
- Health & Wellness
- Cultural and Creative Industries and Sectors
- Advanced Technologies (KETs)

[3] More information in the Evaluation of RIS3 Aragón 2014-2020. https://www.aragon.es/-/ris-3-y-s3-aragon-estrategia-de-investigacion-e-innovacion-para-una-especializacion-inteligente

The table below summarizes the specific objectives and the strategic lines of Aragón's S3 with a strong focus on supporting innovative SMES and innovation ecosystems, and the key programmes foreseen for their implementation:

SPECIFIC OBJECTIVES	STRATEGIC LINES	PROGRAMMES
SO 1/ Guide and boost Aragón's industrial transition	SL 1/ Industrial modernisation	P1/ Modernisation and competitiveness of the industry based on innovation
		P2/ Creation, modernisation, diversification and development of innovative initiatives for services connected to industry
		P3/ Design for industrial development
		P4/ Initiatives for the use of instruments that promote innovation, such as Public Procurement of Innovation, Technology Vouchers, among others
		P5/ Promote synergies between strategic planning initiatives for R&D&I and industry (e.g., artificial intelligence, circular economy, industry)
	SL 2/ Boosting the creation and strengthening of R&D&I ecosystems in areas of specialisation	P6/ Coordination and collaboration between financing instruments that enable knowledge transfer
		P8/ Digital Innovation Hub
		P9/ Promote financing tools and instruments that facilitate public–private collaboration and the integration of innovation and knowledge generated for the benefit of society, fostering excellence
	SL 3/ Promotion of a Cluster policy	P10/ Strengthening Clusters to ensure that their actions are directed towards areas of specialisation, overcoming business sector silos
		P11/ Cooperation for the internationalisation of Aragonese companies, technologies, and R&D&I
SO 2/ Strengthen Aragón's R&D&I system to meet the recovery and transformation needs of the productive fabric	SL 4/ Promoting efficiency and coordination of Technology Centres through agents that facilitate cooperation between them	P12/ Support programme for Technology Centres for strategic projects in cooperation between two or more Centres, and with companies
		P13/ Support for collaborative projects between Technology Centres and companies
		P14/ Network of Technology Centres
	SL 5/ Incentives for the creation and strengthening of the R&D&I ecosystem in S3 areas	P15/ Development of pilot projects for vertical integration in specialisation areas
	SL 6/ Bringing capacities, especially public ones, in research and innovation closer to the territory, encouraging the digital and ecological transition	P16/ Strengthening coordination between actors to bring innovation and technology closer to companies in the territory, equipping them with competitive intelligence
		P17/ Strengthening and dissemination of the R&D&I Governance system in Aragón, also facilitating the participation of Aragonese R&D&I actors and civil society
		P18/ Digital transformation of companies and society in the territory
		P19/ Ecological transition of the socio-economic fabric in the territory
SO 3/ Position and promote Aragón's knowledge and technology in regional, national, and international markets	SL 7/ Networks and platforms for smart specialisation	P20/ Strengthening and coordination of smart specialisation networks and platforms in which Aragón participates
	SL 8/ Support for the knowSLdge and technology transfer-based economy	P23/ Support for transfer: valorisation of knowledge, technology, and intellectual property
		P24/ Dissemination of science and Key Enabling Technologies (KETs) to society and the productive sector
SO 4/ Create, attract and retain talent in Aragón	SL 9/ Promotion of innovative educational programmes to acquire the necessary capacities, skills and abilities	P25/ Postgraduate programmes in areas aligned with the S3
		P26/ Dual training for innovation in entrepreneurship, sustainability, circular economy and digital transition
		P27/ Aragón Talent Network: creation, attraction, and retention.
		P28/ Continuing education
	SL10/ Innovative and technology-based entrepreneurship	P29/ Open innovation
		P30/ Promotion of entrepreneurship and growth of emerging and scaling-up companies

i. Alignment of the ecosystems selected with the S3 strategy

The ecosystems proposed for this assignment are aligned with the regional priorities. Water has long been a strategic area for the region, already featured in past RIS3 and currently in this S3. Water has close links to S3 priorities of Agro-food, like healthy agrifood, efficient water management in food industry among others, and Energy specially the sustainability aspect and water management in the production of renewables like hydrogen. However, it previously received less attention compared to other sectoral or economic areas. With the growing urgency of climate change, interest

in water-related innovation is now increasing. And other regional industries apart of water management industry are considering water-related innovation as a strategic topic.

Digital and Artificial Intelligence is a cross-cutting theme, explicitly recognised within the priority on Advanced Technologies (KETs) but its impact goes much further. It has the potential to accelerate processes, improve public services, and create new business opportunities in strategic sectors such as health, agri-food, mobility, and advanced manufacturing.

The public sector in Aragon plays a decisive role in driving this transformation. While Spain performs well in European rankings for e-government and connectivity, the deployment of AI is still at an early stage and the joint development of projects in the public administration may pull from innovative regional SMES.

Moreover, the presence of data centres in the region represents a strategic opportunity. These centres not only reinforce the digital infrastructure but can also become key nodes for training, experimentation, and collaboration between companies and technology centres. Seizing this potential will require improved coordination among ecosystem actors and the support of public entities—such as the Aragón Institute of Technology (ITA), the Departments of Innovation and Electronic Administration. Through the DGPII, strategies can be developed to catalyse the uptake of AI and digital technologies across the SMES and regional industry.

Although Security and Defence are not explicitly defined as priorities in Aragón's S3, the region's long-standing capabilities in this domain present a strategic opportunity. The recent national and European momentum in defence policy, especially around dual-use technologies, offers Aragón the chance to reactivate and reposition this sector within its broader industrial ecosystem.

This opportunity aligns particularly well with existing S3 priorities such as automotive, logistics, ICT, energy, and advanced materials. Strengthening industrial capacities in these areas can contribute significantly to security and defence objectives, while also benefiting from them through innovation, investment, and diversification.

The defence-related activities in Aragón, while rooted in military potential, are primarily dual-use oriented, involving enterprises, research centres, and clusters. Key actors such as AERA (aerospace) and AITIIP (advanced materials) illustrate how the region can mobilise its ecosystem towards defence-related innovation without departing from its smart specialisation logic paving the way for strategic investments in key regional industries.

Thus, while not a formal priority, Security and Defence intersect indirectly with S3 through transversal themes like advanced technologies (KETs) and industrial transformation, offering a path for mutual reinforcement and ringfence key investments.

c. Plan de Innovacion 2024-2027

Promoted by the DGPII, the Aragón Innovation Plan 2024–2027 aims to strengthen the region's business competitiveness and position Aragón as a leading innovation hub at both national and international levels. The plan aims to reinforce the S3 Aragon 2021-2027 and responds to the need to overcome siloed working practices and limited coordination among system actors—issues that have been further accentuated by the institutional separation between the departments responsible for research and university and for innovation.

The plan is structured around three key lines of action:

Effective coordination: The creation of the Innovation Office (*Oficina de Innovación)* is promoted as a key instrument to revitalise the regional innovation ecosystem. It aims to foster synergies among advisory bodies and working groups, strengthen connections between public and private stakeholders, and offer advisory services and information on funding opportunities. Overall, it contributes to more streamlined and effective innovation governance in the region.

Positioning Aragón: This axis promotes initiatives to enhance Aragón's innovative profile and reinforce its presence in strategic spaces at regional, national and European level.

Support and Incentives for collaboration: New mechanisms will be launched by the reginal government to:

- Promote collaboration among companies, technology centres, universities, and other actors in the innovation system
- Support participation in national programmes by fostering the complementarity of funding sources
- Address regional challenges through network-based collaborative projects.
- Support to companies to implement projects in technological centres

d. The Innovation Office

The Innovation Office *(Oficina de Innovación)* is an initiative of the DGPII, in collaboration with other public entities in Aragón. Its aim is to strengthen the regional innovation ecosystem by facilitating coordination among key actors and supporting the implementation of strategic actions to advance in the dynamization of the regional ecosystem.

The Office is structured through an agreement *(convenio)* between various entities of the Government of Aragón, each contributing resources, expertise, and networks with a shared commitment to collaborate. This agreement has been validated by the Government Council (*Consejo de Gobierno*) in May 2025. The signatory entities include:

- Directorate General for Industrial Promotion and Innovation (Coordinator)
- Aragón Exterior (AREX)
- Instituto Aragonés de Ciencias de la Salud (IACS)

- Instituto Tecnológico de Aragón (ITA)

However, the Office is already informally in place, delivering various initiatives such as the working groups aimed at accelerating the regional innovation ecosystems.

Overview of the type of actions

The is currently working on an action plan and securing budget. The types of action are the following:

- The activation of sectoral working groups linked to strategic ecosystems such as defence and water management
- The organisation of open reflection groups (InnoHub) to improve public policies and foster innovation projects through a participatory approach of the regional innovation ecosystem
- Specific support to areas were promotion is needed like participation in European projects, networks and platforms

e. Other public entities that support innovation

In addition to the DGPII, several other entities within the regional administration of Aragón play a key role in fostering innovation. The Directorate-General for Science and Research (*DG de Ciencia e Investigación*) holds legal competence to design and coordinate regional research and science policy. Other sector-specific departments—such as the Directorate-General for SMEs and the Self-Employed *(DG de Pymes y Autónomos)*, the Department of Agriculture, and the Department of Environment—also promote innovation within their respective domains.

A distinctive strength of Aragón's ecosystem is the presence of several publicly funded organisations dedicated to promoting research, development, and innovation. These include:

- ITA (Instituto Tecnológico de Aragón): A leading public technology centre focused on applied research, industrial innovation, and technology transfer, particularly in advanced manufacturing and digitalisation.
- IACS (Instituto Aragónés de Ciencias de la Salud): A reference centre in biomedical research, innovation in healthcare systems, and health data analytics.
- IAF (Instituto Aragónés de Fomento): The regional development agency that supports business competitiveness, entrepreneurship, and the growth of the innovation ecosystem.
- CITA (Centro de Investigación y Tecnología Agroalimentaria de Aragón): A research centre specialised in agri-food innovation, sustainable agriculture, and rural development.
- AREX (Aragón Exterior): The internationalisation agency of Aragón that supports companies and institutions in accessing foreign markets and European programmes.

- CEEI Aragón. (Centro Europeo de Empresas e Innovación de Aragón). CEEI Aragón is a Business and Innovation Centre (BIC) that supports startups and entrepreneurs through incubation, training, and access to funding. It fosters innovation and competitiveness in the Aragon region.

In addition to these public bodies, private non-profit technological centres also play an essential role in the ecosystem. Examples include:

- AITIIP: A non-profit foundation established as private technology centre that drives innovation in advanced manufacturing, plastics and composites, prototyping, and Industry 4.0
- CIRCE (Centro de Investigación de Recursos y Consumos Energéticos): A non-profit foundation dedicated to applied research in energy efficiency, sustainability, and renewable energy technologies, with strong international project participation

f. Participation in regional networks

i. Support from the Innovation Office

In reinforcing the visibility and internal cohesion of the regional innovation ecosystem, in line with the objectives of the Aragón Innovation Plan. It does so by supporting two complementary levels of collaboration:

Innohubs

The Innohubs are a key initiative promoted by the Directorate-General for Industrial Promotion and Innovation in Aragón to enhance coordination, interaction, and collective intelligence within the regional innovation ecosystem. They serve as periodic meeting spaces—held approximately every three months—where stakeholders from across the ecosystem come together to connect, reflect, and co-design strategies for the region's innovation future.

These gatherings are not merely informational; they are designed to be interactive, thematic, and dynamic, allowing participants to engage in structured conversations and creative exercises. Later sessions focused on mapping actors and identifying strategic needs, laying the groundwork for critical initiatives like the Innovation Plan and the creation of the Innovation Office.

Each Innohub session is typically structured around a specific theme or goal. Examples include:

- Understanding how the ecosystem sees itself
- Mapping actors and identifying shared challenges
- Presenting strategic plans like the Innovation Plan

- Facilitating networking and collaboration, such as short pitches from universities to engage businesses

In essence, Innohubs have been instrumental in:

- Fostering mutual awareness among ecosystem actors who often didn't know each other despite operating in the same region
- Identifying key challenges and opportunities
- Activating collaborations and co-creating new lines of work
- Structuring the governance model of the innovation strategy, aligning it with the governance levels of the regional S3 (Smart Specialisation Strategy)
- As an evolving platform, Innohubs continue to shape the strategic direction of Aragón's innovation ecosystem, ensuring it is inclusive, well-connected, and agile in addressing both regional needs and international opportunities

Working Groups in Strategic Areas – The Seed of Future Ecosystem Hubs

Building on insights from the Innohubs, working groups have emerged from this research and innovation system governance promoted by the DGPII. The initiative has led to the formation of working groups in strategic areas like hydrogen, water, industrial digitalisation, and defence. Some of these areas are more mature and already coordinated by specific departments or agencies, while others are still being nurtured by the Directorate General and the Innovation Office. Over time, the aim is for each group to evolve into an autonomous, stakeholder-driven hub with clear leadership, goals, and operational capacity.

An illustrative example is the Water and the Digitalisation Hubs, initially supported by the DGPII, which has now transitioned to a more independent structures coordinated by relevant stakeholders.

ii. Clusters

Clusters have traditionally been key actors in Aragón's innovation ecosystem. They promote collaboration, facilitate innovation projects, and support competitiveness across their member companies and organisations. The region hosts a diverse and dynamic set of clusters, including:

- ALIA (Clúster Logístico de Aragón) – Logistics and transport. Focuses on improving supply chain, logistics services, and transport solutions.
- AERA (Clúster Aeronáutico de Aragón) – Aerospace. Brings together companies and research centres in the aviation and aerospace industry.
- i+Porc (Clúster Español del Sector Porcino) – Agri-food / Pig farming. Innovation in the pork production value chain, from farming to processing.

- CAAR (Clúster de Automoción de Aragón) – Automotive. Represents suppliers and manufacturers in the automotive sector.
- IDIA (Investigación, Desarrollo e Innovación en Aragón) – ICT / Cross-sector R&D. Promotes innovation and collaborative research projects in ICT and data.
- TECNARA (Clúster TIC de Aragón) – ICT and software technologies. Focus on digital technologies, software development, and digital transformation.
- ZINNAE – Water efficiency and environment. Innovation in water use, management, and sustainability.
- TSAC (Clúster de Turismo Sostenible de Aragón) – Health tech and care solutions. Development of technologies for healthcare and social care services.
- Clúster Energía Aragón – Energy and renewables. Innovation and development in energy efficiency, renewable energies, and smart grids.
- CLADA (Clúster Audiovisual de Aragón) – Audiovisual and creative industries. Supports professionals and companies in media, film, and content creation.
- Arahealth (Aragón Health Cluster) – Health and medical technologies. Encompasses healthcare providers, pharma, biotech, and medtech innovation.
- AECAE – Elevator components. Specializes in the manufacture and innovation of elevator and lift components.
- ANMOPYC – Construction and mining machinery Association of manufacturers of machinery for construction, public works, and mining.
- CAMPAG (Cluster Agroalimentario de Aragón) – Agri-food and food processing. Supports innovation and competitiveness in the food production and agro-industrial sectors
- FH2 (Fundación Hidrógeno Aragón) – Hydrogen and clean energy. Promotes the use of hydrogen technologies and their industrial application.
- CICA (Cluster de construccion de Aragón
- Other clusters under development includes Industrial Chemistry and Sports-related industries

iii. The ecosystem in water counts with experienced and active entities that should be additionally supported to unlock regional potential in water:

- ZINNAE signed a strategic agreement with the Instituto Aragónés del Agua to support demonstration projects and training on water regulation and wastewater treatment
- ZINNAE also co-leads the European platform Water Smart Territories (Inforegio) together with the Government of Aragón

- Fundación Hidrógeno Aragón develops green hydrogen projects with partners like DH2 and georeferencing companies
- Fundación Hidrógeno Aragón coordinates the European platform de s3 hydrogen valley, together with the Government of Aragón
- Instituto Pirenaico de Ecología (CSIC) contributes to cross-border initiatives like the Comunidad de Trabajo de los Pirineos and the Observatorio Pirenaico de Cambio Climático
- Fundación CIRCE supports sustainability projects such as water and climate-focused collaborations with local authorities like Zaragoza City Council

There is a strong base to promote further collaborations at regional and European level in the water sector.

iv. Security and defence innovation in Aragón is gaining momentum through various interconnected initiatives:

- The Security and Defence Hub is evolving into a collaborative platform for research and innovation, dual-use technology and industrial capabilities
- Participation in national platforms such as FENAI, the Patronal de Defensa, Fundación Círculo, and Grupo REPER Defensa Potencial strengthen regional-national coordination
- Clusters like ALIA,CAAR and AERA contribute with transport, logistics and aerospace expertise
- The recently launched logistics and industrial hub for defence forms the backbone of Aragón's future innovation network in this strategic field

v. Initiatives in Digitalisation, AI and Public Digitalisation

Several actors contribute to Aragón's positioning as a hub for digital innovation, particularly in artificial intelligence and public sector transformation:

- The University of Zaragoza plays a strategic role, with strong participation in regional and national programmes, including collaboration with the DG of Universities and participation in PERTES and clusters. Its network of 15 institutes ensures continuity between research and policy
- IDIA leads the GEN IA , a strategic European network programme that integrates regional digital infrastructure and connects businesses, academia, and institutions. Companies like Stellantis and Adidas are active participants in the IDIA cluster.
- CIRCE collaborates with clusters to develop scalable AI use cases, such as computer vision for recycling.

- Public administration actors coordinate targeted digitalisation pilots through working groups led by the regional Presidency, with strategic partnerships with companies like Microsoft and AWS
- TECNARA, ITA, AST and the Directorate-General of Digital Transformation are active players in this field.

There is a solid base of intermediaries to support the progress in AI in the public sector and pull from innovative SMES in the region and connect them to European platforms and projects.

g. Participation in European networks

Aragón has taken important steps to strengthen the internationalisation of its science, technology, and innovation ecosystem, particularly through the coordination of various actors within the regional government. Multiple departments and public bodies are actively involved in supporting the participation of regional stakeholders in European and international initiatives.

One of the main instruments supporting internationalisation is the promotion of participation in European networks and platforms. The DGPII has mapped a total of 34 networks, of which the regional government financially supports 21 through membership fees. Additionally, Aragón is involved in 7 European partnerships and participates in 8 S3 thematic platforms—acting as coordinator in 4 of them, alongside co-leader regions.[4]

Table 1: List of S3 platforms with participation from Aragón

Role	S3 Platform	Participating entities
Co-leaders	Safe and Sustainable Mobility (SSM)	ITA, Aragón Exterior
	Cultural and Creative Regional Ecosystems (CCRE)	Aragón Exterior
	Water Smart Territories (WST)	ZINNAE, Aragón Exterior, IAA, DGPII
	Hydrogen Valleys (HV)	Fundación Hidrógeno Aragón, Aragón Exterior, DGPII
Participants	High Tech Farming	ITA, CMAA
	High Traceability and Big Data in the Agri-Food Value Chain	ITA, FITA
	S3 Medtech Platform	CSIC, Arahealth
	Materiales avanzados en baterías	CSIC, Aragón Exterior

[4] The full list of networks and partnerships is in annexe 2

In parallel, specific support measures have been put in place for innovation clusters, notably through the efforts of AREX (Aragón Exterior), offering tailored assistance for engaging in international markets and preparing for competitive European programmes. Support for the EIC Accelerator from AIREX in Zaragoza, though currently limited in scope and results, it is a good initiative that once set in place needs to be further reinforced.

Additionally, the Directorate-General for Science and Research (DG Ciencia) provides financial support to other entities—such as INMA, recognised under the Severo Ochoa programme, an excellence research programme from the Spanish Ministry of Science.

Several successful initiatives highlight the impact of these support schemes. For example:

- The ZINNAE cluster has strengthened its international positioning through involvement in S3 platforms
- Collaborative work by CAAR and the ZINNAE cluster has fostered new international connections
- Initiatives aimed at the recovery of protected species show innovation's role in addressing environmental challenges.
- IDIA and GENAI

Other public entities like AREX, CITA, IACS, ITA and University of Zaragoza units also play a role, independently advancing international partnerships and participation in EU projects.

4. Challenges in the regional system: a fragmented approach to regional and international collaboration in innovation

The fieldwork conducted through focus groups and participatory workshops has revealed a range of challenges that hinder the consolidation and strategic evolution of Aragón's regional innovation ecosystem. These challenges are present across the three case study ecosystems—water, security and defence, and digitalisation with a focus on public sector AI—and reflect broader gaps in coordination, policy development, and international positioning.

This section presents the key obstacles grouped under four interrelated areas:

- Consolidating the regional ecosystem
- Policy and instruments
- Positioning
- Internal coordination in the regional government

Next there is an outline of the mentioned obstacles that are common to the three ecosystems with specific description of each case:

a. Consolidating the regional ecosystem

Aragón's innovation ecosystem shows positive signs of growing engagement and an increasing number of collaborative initiatives. However, according to stakeholder input and other studies like the CIRCE report, the ecosystems under study—water, defence, and digital and AI in the public sector—are still not mature or strongly connected. There are common challenges related to ecosystem consolidation worth to mention:

i. Leadership and coordination

The role of key entities in promoting and organising a common space where actors can meet, exchange, and collaborate is considered essential, particularly in ecosystems with limited tradition of coordinated action like these three ecosystems. In less mature ecosystems, where resources are scarce and links between actors are weak, effective coordination is critical to improve efficiency, avoid duplication of efforts, and ensure that innovation initiatives are aligned and mutually reinforcing.

In the water ecosystem, the cluster ZINNAE plays a central role in activating cooperation and helping member companies access innovation opportunities. However, its resources are limited and do not fully cover the needs of the wider ecosystem, specially the less innovative SMEs or companies less used to international projects that need closer and specific support. Another major challenge remains the lack of critical mass and weak connections, especially with the industrial sector, which limits broader participation and the diffusion of knowledge and technology to the market and address societal challenges.

Expanding engagement, especially among SMEs and industrial actors, is essential to strengthen the ecosystem. Local stakeholders should be encouraged to lead regional demonstration projects that can later be scaled and replicated in other contexts, promoting technology transfer and ecosystem consolidation.

Box 1: WaterCampus Leeuwarden: Water technology solutions through an open innovation ecosystem with pivotal linkage to S3

WaterCampus Leeuwarden is an open innovation ecosystem focused on water technology, located in Friesland, Northern Netherlands. Established in 2003, WaterCampus stimulates cooperation between (inter)national businesses, knowledge institutes and governments within the water technology sector.

The WaterCampus facilitates collaborative business and technological innovation, contributing significantly to the green transition and global water solutions. It is a key player in the Smart Specialisation Strategy (S3) for Northern Netherlands, with an active participation in the regional Entrepreneurial Discovery Process (EDP), enhancing the regional innovation ecosystem. The Water Campus is global initiatives, including the coordination of the EU-level "Water Smart Territories" S3 Thematic Platform where Aragon is also a coordinator.

Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem remains in the extensive experience in European research and innovation projects and the large cooperation network with international companies not based in NL as well as the close cooperation with local and regional authorities in regional ecosystem dynamization activities.

To address these gaps, there is a strong need for shared leadership. Establishing a Water Innovation Hub with balanced participation from intermediaries like ZINNAE, universities, technology centres, public authorities, and companies would help structure collaboration and build synergies across sectors, enhancing Aragón's positioning in water-related innovation.

In the security and defence ecosystem, a new innovation hub has recently emerged with active participation from companies, research centres, universities, and entities from the Spanish Army based in Aragón. Thanks to the initial promotion by the Innovation Office, which organised the first meetings, structured the discussions, and supported the creation of the first strategic documents, the initiative has generated high levels of motivation and commitment across stakeholders. However, there are still open questions regarding long-term leadership and governance. Dedicated resources and clear institutional anchoring, particularly with the Ministry of Defence, will be key to ensuring the sustainability of the hub and its evolution into a fully functional platform.

Box 2: SAFE Cluster drives innovation in security and dual-use technologies across Europe

The SAFE Cluster in PACA focuses on aerospace, defence, and security technologies. It supports SMEs, large enterprises, and research institutions in areas of expertise that include satellite technologies, cybersecurity for defence applications, and unmanned aerial vehicles. The cluster promotes collaboration, supports R&D initiatives and participation in European funding programmes, and integrates SMEs into global value chains. With over 400 members, SAFE Cluster drives innovation in security and dual-use technologies across Europe.

The interest of Aragon relies on collaborating with Region Provence Alpes Cote d'Azur in shared priorities in cybersecurity, unmanned systems, and dual-use technologies. On the other hand, SAFE Cluster expertise aligns with Aragón's strengths in advanced logistics, energy-efficient systems, and additive manufacturing.

In the digital and AI ecosystem with a focus in the public sector, public administration may be instrumental to push for innovation. The regional government shall promote internally broad initiatives to identify relevant digitalisation and AI-related challenges that could be addressed collaboratively with local businesses and research actors. Also, the creation of dedicated offices or nodes to catalyse all the challenges and opportunities will help in this regard.

Although initial efforts have been made, including the implementation of first use cases in the regional administration, these challenges are not always clearly communicated—even within the regional administration—and awareness across the ecosystem remains limited. There is a need to develop early-stage demand mapping, identify concrete use cases, and launch market consultations followed by public procurement of innovation.

Box 3: IACS: Health innovation through an organic ecosystem linked to regional smart specialisation

The *Unidad de Innovación* of the *Instituto Aragonés de Ciencias de la Salud* (IACS) promotes an organic health innovation ecosystem in Aragón, built around the needs of the regional health system. It engages public hospitals, professionals, and regional stakeholders in a collaborative framework that supports demand-driven innovation.

IACS plays a central role in fostering Public Procurement of Innovation (PPI) in health, notably through the *Cátedra IACS de CPI en Salud* at the University of Zaragoza. Since 2016, it has helped design and implement Aragón's CPI strategy and supports health institutions from problem definition to execution of innovation procurement projects.

The unit also contributes. to European innovation leadership through initiatives in PPI such as ROSIA, Procure4Health, and Transforming Health and Care System (THCS), linking local health needs with European transformation agendas. IACS is aligned with Aragón's Smart Specialisation Strategy (S3) and supports the regional Entrepreneurial Discovery Process by connecting public procurement with research and business capabilities.

Its extensive training programme aimed at enhancing healthcare professionals' competencies in areas like communication, patient safety, and research it is worth to mention. Particular emphasis is placed on European project participation (e.g., Horizon Europe). The unit provides practical tools such as short guides and 40-minute recorded video sessions, outlining the strategic calls relevant to Aragón's health researchers and practitioners.

Strengthening regional networks requires not only the active participation of key stakeholders in projects and funding and tender calls, but also a coordinated approach that fosters internal collaboration, connecting supply and demand, and bringing together knowledge in research, development, and innovation with market and public sector applications.

AI training for public servants, businesses, and academic institutions—including vocational education—is also an emerging need.

Box 4: Training programme in artificial intelligence for public servants

Launched in 2021 by the Department of Public Expenditure & Reform of Ireland, the Foundation Certificate in Artificial Intelligence is a 12-week training programme designed to enhance the digital skills of Ireland's public servants. The course covers tools, programming, ethics, and project management in AI. Funded by local governments, the initiative highlights the importance of building AI competencies within public administration to strengthen digitisation strategies and policies.

The programme underscores the critical role of upskilling public servants in leveraging AI for efficient governance. Its success demonstrates the potential for mutualisation among public authorities and integration into comprehensive digital skill-building strategies. It aligns with EU objectives for digital transformation and smart government.

ii. Shared vision and objectives

A significant barrier to consolidation of these ecosystems is the lack of a shared vision and agreed objectives among ecosystem actors. Stakeholders often pursue individual agendas, and collaborative projects rarely emerge from a common strategic roadmap. This misalignment limits the impact of public and private efforts and prevents the ecosystems from advancing as a unified force. In the security and defence and the water ecosystem, strategic diagnosis have been made at ecosystem level, that should lead to

concrete roadmap with concrete objectives and actions. These plans, that shall be developed together or backed by the regional government, needs to be finalised with high level of operationalisation and with real possibilities to be implemented using private and public financing, through regional, national and European instruments. In this regard, the need for shared visions and priorities should be followed by comprehensive mapping of actors and capacities in the region.

iii. Mapping of actors, capacities and opportunities

The actors within the region's three innovation ecosystems generally know each other and are aware of each other's activities, especially among companies and private technology centres, where connections and roles are clearer. However, engagement with the public sector, and coordination within it, is weaker due to public sector departments working in silos and limited information sharing. This fragmentation limits the region's ability to build coordinated innovation strategies and identify complementarities between actors. It is essential to develop strategies, supported by dedicated budgets and concrete actions, to strengthen these connections and foster collaboration across all stakeholders.

However, not all relevant actors are identified. the current mapping efforts do not sufficiently capture the specific capabilities, sectoral expertise, or innovation potential of key players, particularly highly performing research groups in universities and technological centres and emerging actors such as startups, entrepreneurs, and innovative SMEs. As a result, valuable partners are often overlooked in regional initiatives and collaborative projects.

In addition, innovation-relevant actors within the regional government are not systematically identified or engaged. Yet, they have a dual role to play, both as sources of innovation challenges and as providers of political and financial support. Not capturing their involvement limits the reach and impact of innovation agendas.

This situation provokes a lack of a comprehensive and update ecosystem maps. A regional map that includes actors' technical expertise, sector focus, available talent, and links to strategic priorities is still missing. This absence makes it difficult to prepare joint project proposals, build strong consortia, and respond efficiently to regional, national, or EU calls.

There is a clear need to invest in tools, processes, and teams capable of regularly updating ecosystem information. Moreover, monitoring systems are critical to track projects —especially those aligned with S3 strategies— who is involved, how, and where collaboration and investment can be better targeted.

Likewise, in the security and defence sector, despite the establishment of the foundation of a soon functioning innovation ecosystem, they still lack a detailed mapping of capabilities in the region linked to the identified regional potentials in the region.

In areas like digital technologies, participants highlighted the absence of a centralised catalogue or mapping of capacities, which makes it difficult to identify potential collaborators, replicate best practices, or build on existing knowledge. Such tools would facilitate the development of thematic networks and open the door to more targeted and strategic partnerships. Another challenge identified is that many businesses does not have a specific strategy on digitalisation, and this prevents their full attention to emerging collaboration opportunities.

Other issue stressed by ecosystem actors is the difficulty to access to information about project and funding opportunities, since the monitoring and viability check is in most cases more time consuming than the resources eager to invest. The existence of ad-hoc teams would ease the burden and help business and other entities to prepare in advance calls, mobilising capabilities and build balanced partnerships.

iv. Sustainability of collaboration

In the water ecosystem, collaboration is often project-based and dependent on the initiative of a few active players. Many projects lack follow-up due to limited innovation capabilities and insufficient engagement from industry, despite water being a cross-cutting issue. The emergence of large-scale investments in Aragón—in energy, green hydrogen, and digitalisation—offers a strategic opportunity to position water as a key enabling factor. However, many industrial players still do not see water as a priority, and collaborative innovation remains underdeveloped. Furthermore, time constraints and limited incentives reduce participation, especially for SMEs.

In security and defence, stakeholders emphasised the need for dedicated policy instruments to support the network's growth, facilitate collaborative innovation projects, and maintain coordination over time. In digital public services and AI, sustained collaboration will depend on long-term investment in capacities, challenge definition, and demand engagement.

b. Policy making and policy instruments

i. Strategic Gaps

Despite the development of several strategic plans at the regional level in recent years, stakeholders across ecosystems recognize that there is either a lack of clearly defined regional strategies with actionable roadmaps and instruments, or that existing strategies lack clarity, budget allocation, or effective implementation tools. Moreover, current instruments are in most cases not fit for the purpose of the strategies and its objectives as they were designed in the past in other context.

In the water ecosystem, the absence of a coherent and action-oriented regional plan significantly limits the capacity to mobilise resources, coordinate efforts, and define a

collective vision. Without a shared strategic framework, it becomes difficult to set priorities, align public funding, or engage meaningfully in national and European innovation networks.

Stakeholders emphasise the need for a regional strategy that integrates water management and climate change priorities with innovation policy and investment planning. Reinforcing the role of water as a regional priority—and clearly articulating its contribution to sustainability and economic development—could enhance Aragón's competitiveness and position the region as a leader in smart water management.

To overcome this gap, strategic planning based on shared, long-term objectives—developed through a quadruple helix approach involving public authorities, industry, academia, and civil society—would provide a strong foundation for the development of long-term thematic agendas that address Aragón's specific regional challenges.

In public digitalisation, the adoption of emerging technologies, such as artificial intelligence and cloud computing, requires a structural transformation supported by clear strategies and adequate funding, including public–private partnerships. In this regard, the lack of strategies developed by all the ecosystem and operational, financial barriers and lack of coordination undermines the potential to identify strategic projects and related regional, national and international calls. In addition, one of the key challenges is the need for the Government of Aragón to present a long-term strategy with comprehensive, rather than ad hoc, measures. This should include clear lines of action, such as the creation of centralised platforms for information sharing and financial support for strategic projects. It is also proposed to establish a network to improve communication between public entities and stakeholders, helping to address issues of overlap and fragmentation.

ii. Lack of tailored funding instruments

Over the past years, Aragón has developed ambitious strategies and policy frameworks, but these have not been accompanied by a modernisation of funding tools. As a result, there is a mismatch between strategic ambitions and the instruments available, creating bottlenecks that delay or prevent the implementation of collaborative innovation projects.

Key limitations identified include:

- Lack of regional calls specifically designed to support collaborative innovation in the regional ecosystem
- Existing support for clusters is valuable, but insufficient to sustain ecosystem-wide collaboration. There is the need to support initiatives that bring together more often SMES and clusters.
- Few instruments supporting knowledge and technology transfer, especially from universities and technology centres to SMEs.

- Lack of targeted calls and other support instruments for less innovative SMEs
- Absence of calls or incentives for startups working on disruptive technologies.
- Support is needed to validate innovative solutions and facilitate their transfer through demonstration environments, enabling results to be scaled and replicated in other regions.
- Support is needed to help companies scale up and develop exploitation plans for their technologies through investments but also ad hoc services like mentoring, business acceleration programmes, and access to specialised advisory services.
- Dependence on national and European programmes (e.g. AEI clusters, Horizon Europe), which have lower success rates and are not always aligned with regional priorities.

Participants also noted the need to align funding calls with pre-identified regional challenges, and to develop support services to help actors to present successful projects answering calls for proposals or navigate EU platforms such as Water Smart Territories. Stakeholders underlined the need for institutional backing to articulate business needs and increase international participation. In addition, stakeholders stressed the opportunity to develop project pipelines in advance, enhancing preparedness for future European funding opportunities.

Finally, regulatory fragmentation and cultural barriers remain relevant obstacles to scaling solutions and creating cross-regional synergies.

c. Positioning

In Aragón, some actors have a strong track record in European research and innovation projects, with established portfolios and international networks. However, one of the main findings of this study is the lack of knowledge spillover—experiences, contacts, and know-how are not sufficiently shared across the broader regional ecosystem. As a result, many stakeholders remain disconnected from European opportunities.

It is essential to strengthen mechanisms that transfer experience from leading organisations to other regional actors, especially SMEs and local governments, and to encourage wider participation in EU-funded initiatives. Fostering this internal diffusion of expertise will allow more actors to engage in international collaboration and enhance the region's collective positioning.

A shared priority across all ecosystems is to enhance Aragón's visibility and strategic participation in European innovation networks and platforms. Although the regional administration is currently mapping its involvement to improve coordination, stakeholders note that institutional support remains fragmented and under-resourced.

Intermediary organisations, which are critical for identifying opportunities, preparing proposals, and building partnerships, often lack the financial and operational support

required to carry out this role effectively. For instance, many SMES in clusters are not equipped to participate in European projects. In the security and defence sector, stakeholders cited the limited capacity of some local companies to respond to international calls and the shortage of specialised personnel for managing EU-funded projects.

For example, AREX which is focused in supporting internationalization of firms from Aragón, currently supports SME participation in EU initiatives, particularly through the EIC Accelerator. While valuable, the initiative requires revision and reinforcement to enhance its effectiveness and achieve its intended goal.

There is a clear need to establish dedicated support structures with technical staff to manage platforms like Water Smart Territories and to foster participation in European partnerships. These platforms help participants to identify partners, share expertise, and expand networks. While various entities like ITA and IACS already support participation in such initiatives, greater synergies among them should be explored. The Innovation Office could also play a role in coordinating all this experience and assisting additional actors interested in joining these platforms. The role of the ITA in the Enterprise Europe Network and their capacities should be also explored and promoted.

Capacity building is another critical gap, particularly among smaller organisations and public institutions. Positive examples, such as the Innovation Unit at IACS, which supports staff training for EU project participation, should be scaled and replicated across sectors.

Without stronger alignment, targeted investment, and dedicated support structures, Aragón risks missing key opportunities to integrate into global value chains and benefit from its participation in European missions, partnerships, and interregional platforms.

d. Internal coordination in the Regional Government of Aragón and measures for internationalisation: Challenges and opportunities

There is a shared understanding among institutional stakeholders of the importance of international engagement. They are committed to supporting the internationalization of science and innovation ecosystem in two keyways: first, by promoting collaboration and their own participation in high-quality R&I projects with international visibility, and second, by enhancing Aragón's presence and reputation in Europe.

However, certain challenges arise for the regional government to have a more active role in both promoting and participating in European/international projects:

Participation in international projects

- Low engagement in international initiatives due to institutional barriers, like budget restrictions or lack of incentives to participation

- Language barriers make it harder for some staff to engage confidently with EU-level processes
- Administrative constraints, such as difficulty hiring staff under project funding frameworks, hinder effective participation

Access to knowledge and capabilities

- Lack of early access to relevant information on calls and programmes makes timely preparation difficult
- Need for better tools and support systems to align international opportunities with internal work planning and administrative cycles
- Difficulty navigating legal frameworks, leading to hesitancy or lack of confidence in participating. (e.g. DNSH)

Mapping and awareness of opportunities

- Public Sector officials highlighted the lack of information regarding funding and project opportunities due to limited visibility over the full landscape of international opportunities
- There is a clear need for better coordination and knowledge-sharing to ensure public sector actors can identify, understand, and act on relevant calls.

In this context, there are several opportunities identified in three main areas

Strategic governance and ecosystem coordination

- It is essential to involve the Government of Aragón beyond mere letters of support—this includes infrastructure, planning, and resource allocation
- Ensure efficient coordination and a strong institutional mandate
- Define a clear positioning focus (political, strategic) and identify regional strengths
- Support public administrations in complying with requirements that may limit participation (e.g., DNSH)
- Disseminate information through newsletters and other channels on funding opportunities and training
- Understand the interests and expectations of local actors from regional ecosystems
- To support this, the development of digital collaboration platforms and networks may facilitate communication, joint planning, and project coordination. Such tools can significantly enhance regional integration, particularly in ecosystems with limited resources, by streamlining interactions and enabling shared strategic action.

Business engagement and capacity building

- Identify companies with the highest potential for EU programme participation
- Make a coordinated effort to attract new companies to internationalisation efforts

- Attracting new companies requires technical and professional outreach and mid-term engagement for measurable impact
- Provide concrete information about calls and help companies prepare proposals
- Offer training and upskilling programmes for staff in companies

Financial support and leveraging resources

- Support investment and facilitate access to private funding opportunities (e.g., Deep Science and Tech, access to private funding for initiatives sus as accelerators, sheed and risk capital)
- Leverage national support schemes to maximise regional participation

The work carried out by the Innovation Office and the DGPII is essential for coordinating and stimulating collaboration within the regional government.

5.Actionable recommendations and planning

Building on the identified challenges above, a set of actions has been defined and prioritised with the participation of the stakeholders in the in person workshops. The resulting list of actions for each of the ecosystem of study, detailed in Annex 3, it is an additional outcome of this assignment and serves as a shared repository of actions to support regional innovation ecosystems in Aragón.

This section identifies a list of actionable recommendations that will strength regional collaboration and international positioning of Aragon and inform next action plan of the Innovation Office. A roadmap for the key actions is then proposed.

a. Actionable recommendations

Ecosystem coordination & visibility: In recent months, the DGPII and the promoted Innovation Office have taken significant steps to position them as a key driver of Aragón's regional innovation ecosystem. These decisive steps need to be maintained and secured with budget to maintain its position as ecosystem broker. Some key actions to maintain the ecosystem coordination are the following:

- **Organise annual ecosystem events:** Create a flagship annual event to connect regional actors, build momentum, generate opportunities, and showcase promising projects.
- **Continue and expand Innohubs:** Maintain quarterly Innohub meetings, to foster cross-sector collaboration and support community building. Innohubs could be further reinforce if explores a deeper thematic focus.
- **Support the development of existing and new working groups into thematic innovation hubs:** Provide methodological, strategic, and facilitation support for emerging ecosystem hubs (e.g., hydrogen, defence, water, digitalisation), until they can be led independently.

Build a knowledge hub: The Innovation Office is already recognised as a key actor in the dynamization of the innovation ecosystem in Aragón. They are in good position to accumulate and disseminate important knowledge about collaboration opportunities at European level that can serve both the regional government and the resto of the ecosystem. To ensure the innovation stakeholders have access to key knowledge and that the measures can be monitored and evaluated to test the performance, the following actions in this filed could be taken:

- **Develop a regional innovation ecosystem map:** Identify and categorise actors, capacities, and thematic expertise, both at general level and by strategic areas.
- **Develop a repository of ecosystem projects and capacities.** Create a centralised information platform with a regularly updated repository that maps key innovation actors, their capacities, and innovation projects across the region. The repository should support internal coordination, partner search, and strategic planning, and be aligned with S3 monitoring efforts. It will serve as a practical tool for ecosystem visibility, collaboration, and informed decision-making.
- **Publish an annual report on the state of the ecosystem**: Include data from surveys, key project highlights, funding mobilised, and roadmap progress. Use this as a communication and engagement tool.

Improve access to resources & funding: Most of the stakeholders don't have enough resources to monitor the opportunities on EU calls. In the other hand some of current regional policy instruments are not fit to serve the objectives proposed by the recent strategies and that are demanded by the innovation ecosystem in the region, the following actions in this filed could be taken:

- **Establish a partner search and funding intelligence service:** Act as a specific knowledge hub for EU funding calls, matchmaking with European partners, and capacity-building for project participation.
- **Evaluate and support the adaptation of innovation support instruments**: Conduct a structured assessment of current regional tools (e.g., grants, subsidies), and propose improvements or new instruments tailored to the ecosystem's evolving needs.
- **Promote soft instruments (e.g., innovation agents):** Promote initiatives to co-fund innovation facilitators in clusters or public-private bodies who can drive EU project development and ecosystem activation from within.

Strengthen the Governance of Aragón's S3 Strategy. The efforts made to revitalize Aragón's innovation ecosystem more effectively and in a coordinated way must also be reflected in the governance of the S3 strategy. The work carried out by the Innovation Office should be integrated into the S3 governance framework to leverage synergies and avoid duplication. It is also important to link the S3 governance with the challenges identified by the ecosystem so they can be addressed collaboratively, based on Aragón's capacities and strengths. The following actions in this filed could be taken:

- **Analyse the alignment of S3 governance** with the actions planned by the Innovation Office.
- **Promote the presentation of challenges by the ecosystem represented in the S3 Governance,** so they can be collaboratively addressed by the broader innovation community. Create expert committees within the ecosystem to transparently identify challenges that can be solved through collaboration between companies, technology centres, and universities in Aragón.
- **Monitor the implementation of the S3 strategy**: Update the monitoring system to track projects, stakeholders, and thematic alignment with the S3 priorities. Link this monitoring to the interventions of the Innovation Office and systematically assess outcomes and impacts.

Strengthen the international positioning of Aragon's innovation ecosystem: While the Government of Aragón currently provides support to clusters for submitting European projects and engaging in networking activities, there is a clear need to go further. This includes establishing dedicated support structures and specialized teams to manage strategic platforms such as Water Smart Territories and to reinforce participation in European partnerships and collaborative networks. Strengthening these areas is essential for building valuable contacts, identifying potential collaborators, and expanding Aragón's international reach. Equally important is creating the right spaces for Aragón's innovation leaders to engage with other regional stakeholders. By enhancing support for participation in EU networks and projects, the Innovation Office can play a pivotal role in boosting the presence and influence of Aragón's innovation actors at both the European and international levels.

- **Map and monitor international network participation:** Identify strategic partnerships and track Aragón's presence in European platforms. Use this mapping to inform targeted support measures that enhance visibility and engagement.
- **Align strategic projects and networks and boost participation** in cross-border consortia and key European initiatives.
- **Support structured internationalization strategies for innovation actors:** Provide guidance, training, and matchmaking services to encourage participation.
- **Help companies define their innovation internationalization strategies** and strengthen their capacity to access European funding.
- **Participate in community of practitioners** to support international collaboration like S3CoP and I3 Instrument.

Capacity building & ecosystem engagement:

- **Facilitate cross-learning between ecosystem actors**: Design short-format presentations (e.g., 5-minute slots) during Innohubs where universities, clusters, or startups can pitch work to potential partners.

- **Encourage shared governance in strategic areas**. Support the gradual transfer of leadership of mature working groups (e.g., hydrogen or defence) to specialized entities, while ensuring coordination.
- **Develop an internal training module for ecosystem management:** Equip Innovation Office staff and collaborators with updated tools and methodologies in innovation governance, design thinking, and EU project development.

b. Roadmap of key actions strengthen the regional ecosystem of Aragón

The above recommendations maybe implemented over different time period, but in the short term a proposed roadmap that could be part of the action plan of the Innovation Office would be the following:

Box 5: Short-Term Actions (2025-2027)

Become the one stop shop for ecosystem coordination and visibility:

- **Organise an annual ecosystem event** A flagship annual event will connect regional actors, build momentum, generate opportunities, and showcase promising projects.
- Continue and **expand Innohubs**. Innovation agents in Aragon will know in first hand all initiatives by the regional government and rest of actors and opportunities for cooperation
- Promote the creation of **new working groups** to advance towards new thematic innovation hubs immature ecosystems will count with support from the innovation office to launch first meeting between potential actors.

Enhancing intelligence for innovation and regional and international collaboration

- Publish an annual report on the state of the ecosystem
- Develop a regional innovation ecosystem map: Identify and categorise actors, capacities, and thematic expertise, both at general level and by strategic areas/sectors
- Create a centralised information platform with a regularly updated repository that maps key innovation actors, their capacities, and innovation projects across the region
- Establish a partner search and funding intelligence service: Act as a specific knowledge hub for EU funding calls, matchmaking with European partners, and capacity-building for project participation.

Conduct a structured assessment of current regional policy instruments and grants that support innovation

- Conduct a structured assessment of current regional tools (e.g., grants, subsidies), and propose improvements or new instruments tailored to the ecosystem's evolving needs.

Integrate Innovation Office efforts in governance:

- Analyse the alignment of S3 governance with the actions planned by the Innovation Office.
- Thematic roundtables organized within S3 Governance and PDE integrated in Innovation Office action plan
- Monitor the implementation of the S3 strategy: Update the monitoring system to track projects, stakeholders, and thematic alignment with the S3 priorities

Integration into regional and EU collaboration:

- **S3 Community of Practice**: Active participation and Attendance to at least two events per year.
- **S3CoP or I3 Instrument**: Apply to host relevant EU conferences in Aragón

Capacity building & ecosystem engagement

- **Develop an internal training module for ecosystem management**. This will equip Innovation Office staff and collaborators with updated tools and methodologies in innovation governance, design thinking, and EU project development.

6. Next steps: the critical role of political commitment

Political commitment is crucial for strengthening innovation ecosystems. It enables the creation of supportive policies, allocates necessary resources, and fosters the cross-sector collaboration needed to consolidate regional innovation efforts and promote strategic projects at interregional levels.

In the case of Aragón, high-level political engagement is essential to support the momentum already generated on the ground. It is also key to improving dialogue and coordination across regional ministries, which currently operate with limited interdepartmental cooperation, contributing to the fragmented ecosystem outlined above.

Although there is a clear support to the actions outlined, it is crucial to ensure that these intentions are translated into concrete measures that align with the vision and needs expressed by stakeholders.

In this regard:

- The commitment to develop a robust action plan for the Innovation Office, backed by adequate resources, is highly welcome.
- Equally important are ongoing efforts to strengthen coordination across regional government departments, and the assurance that policy instruments are fit for purpose and serve the objectives established in regional strategies elaborated through participatory processes in recent years. Assessing the current policy instruments supporting research and innovation would be a valuable step to ensure that strategic goals are effectively supported by the appropriate tools.

There is a strong demand from stakeholders for a clear strategic positioning of Aragón's innovation policy. This can only be achieved through bold and coordinated political action.

Annexes

Annex I – Identification of other regions with similar strategic objectives and good practices

This document is part of the activities planned in the targeted support assignment to the region of Aragon in the frame of the activities of the S3 Community of Practice lead by DG REGIO. The authorities of the regional government of Aragón are committed to strengthening the region's innovation ecosystem by enhancing its visibility and impact in European and international research and innovation networks. In the frame of their S3 priorities, they aim to leverage the existing strengths and presence of leading Aragón's innovation actors in innovation European and programmes fostering innovation across the rest of region's innovation actors and SMES.

As part of the planned activities, there is an interest in identifying other actors in European regions with similar strategic objectives and priorities, with the dual aim of:

- building partnerships for innovation projects in related fields
- fostering knowledge sharing of relevant initiatives, organizations, and best practices that promote innovation.

By identifying good practices from other EU regions and territories the regional authorities will be better positioned to understand how to valorise existing collaborative networks with a view to improve the international projection of the region

This analysis aims to identify regions with similar objectives and priority areas within the selected thematic focus areas of this assignment: water, security and defence, and digitalisation, with a particular emphasis on artificial intelligence (AI). The work has been conducted through a combination of searches in key strategic databases, including the S3CoP Observatory and publications such as those from the Joint Research Centre (JRC), alongside targeted searches for specific projects in the Horizon CORDIS database.

The following sections provide an indicative identification and analysis of regions with strategic objectives aligned with those of Aragon for this assignment. Each section begins with a list of regions sharing similar S3 priorities, as identified through the S3CoP Observatory, which consolidates all S3 strategies across Europe. This is complemented by key contact details for each region. Additionally, a selection of good practices is presented and analysed in detail, focusing on their main characteristics, strengths, networks, and potential relevance to Aragon. Each section concludes with a curated list of thematic networks, initiatives, and events of interest to Aragon, designed to foster collaboration and engagement, particularly for the regional administration.

i. Water

Based on the topics of European and national innovation projects[5], Aragón's interests span from broad to specific areas related to the triple transition (green, digital, and resilience). These interests include addressing challenges in water consumption and pollution, improving water use efficiency and environmental sustainability, advancing wastewater treatment, promoting climate-resilient and environmentally sustainable water transport and inland waterways, and developing water technologies to support environmental sustainability and a circular economy

We have identified regions/provinces with strategic objectives like Aragon:

Data was extracted from the S3 CoP Observatory database and in the cases that this information was not available it was extracted from web search and desk research.

Region name	S3 Priorities	Name	Position	Contact
Wallon Region (BE)	Circular materials - Circular economy	Florence Hennart	Public Service of Wallonia - Economic Policy Directorate	s3.economie@spw.wallonie.be
Kymenlaakso (FI)	Biocircular economy	Petri Tolmunen	Head of International Affairs, RIS3	petri.tolmunen@kymenlaakso.fi
Lapland (FI)	Circular economy	Kaarina Mäcklin	Regional Council of Lapland	kaarina.macklin@lapinliitto.fi
North Karelia (FI)	Clean solutions and a green transition	Maarit Intke	Regional Council of Pohjois-Savo	maarit.intke@pohjois-savo.fi
Northern Savonia (FI)	Smart Water system	Regional Council of Pohjois-Savo	Regional Council	info@pohjois-savo.fi
Satakunta (FI)	Blue economy	Katja Laitinen	Regional Council of Satakunta	katja.laitinen@satakunta.fi
South Savo (FI)	Water	Tuula Kokkonen	Manager, Business and Innovation	tuula.kokkonen@esavo.fi
Brittany (FR)	Maritime economy for blue growth	Aurelie Thomas	Regional Council of Brittany - Conseil régional de Bretagne	aurelie.thomas@bretagne.bzh
Grand Est (FR)	Recycling and functionaliza	Romain Fehr	Région GRAND-EST	romain.fehr@grandest.fr

[5] Topics of projects with participation of entities from Aragón in the programmes Horizon Europe and Agrupaciones Empresariales Innovadoras

Region name	S3 Priorities	Name	Position	Contact
	tion of materials for industry and construction			
Normandy (FR)	Resilience facing technology, climate, natural or social risks	Zoe Buyle-Bodin;Romuald Glowacki	Normandie Region	zoe.buylebodin@normandie.fr antenne.bruxelles@normandie.fr romuald.glowacki@normandie.fr
Bremen (DE)	Sustainable economic activity and resource efficiency	Caroline Privat	Ministry of Economic Affairs, Ports and Transformation Free Hanseatic City of Bremen	caroline.privat@wae.bremen.de
Central Macedonia (GR)	Environment and Circular Economy	Goulaptsi Maria	Region of Central Macedonia	m.goulaptsi@pkm.gov.gr
Emilia Romagna (IT)	Climate and natural resources (air, water, land)	Angelica Laterza	Regione Emilia-Romagna	Angelica.Laterza@regione.emilia-romagna.it
Lombardia (IT)	Sustainability	Regione Lombardia	Regional Government	urp@regione.lombardia.it
Puglia (IT)	Energy and environmental systems	Silvia Visciano	Regione Puglia	s.visciano@regione.puglia.it
Loris (PL)	Energy (including EE, RES)	Gabriel Bednarczyk		bednarczyk.gabriel@bppwl.lodzkie.pl zin@bppwl.lodzkie.pl
Lubuskie Province (PL)	Green Economy	Dominik Majchrowski	Marshal Office of Lubelskie Voivodship	dominik.majchrowski@lubelskie.pl
Madeira (PT)	Circular Economy, Energy Transition, Climate Action, and Biodiversity Marine resources and technologies	Sara Relvas;Alberto Velez-Grilo	Unidade de Implementação da Estratégia Regional de Especialização Inteligente;Secretaria Regional da Educação;Ciência e Tecnologia	sara.relvas@madeira.gov.pt alberto.velezgrilo@madeira.gov.pt

Region name	S3 Priorities	Name	Position	Contact
Alentejo (PT)	Sustainable energy	Tiago Pereira	MA Alentejo Program	tiago.pereira@ccdr-a.gov.pt
North-East (RO)	Energy and environment	Gabriela Macoveiu	NORTH-EAST REGIONAL DEVELOPMENT AGENCY	bgris3@adrnordest.ro
South Muntenia West (RO)	Environment and Circular Economy	South Muntenia Regional Development Agency	South Muntenia Regional Development Agency	office@adrmuntenia.ro
Västerbotten County (SE)	sustainable energy systems	Region Västerbotten	Regional Government	regionen@regionvasterbotten.se
Jämtland County (SE)	Soil, Forests, and Water	Amelie Rahbek	Contact point innovation investments from the Managing Authority	amelie.rahbek@regionjh.se
Varmland (SE)	green energy and sustainable local development	Anders Olsson	Region Värmland	anders.olsson@regionvarmland.se
North Netherlands (NL)	Transition from a linear to a circular economy	Northern Netherlands Alliance (SNN)	Managing Authority for Northern Netherlands	info@snn.eu
South Netherlands (NL)	climate adaptation	Stimulus Programme Management	Managing Authority for South Netherlands Operational Programme	info@stimulus.nl
Canary island (ES)	Blue economy industry	Avelino Yanes López	Instituto Tecnológico de Canarias	ayanes@itccanarias.org
Denmark	Environmental technology	Tej Egefjord	Danish Business Authority	tejege@erst.dk de@erst.dk
Luxembourg	Sustainable and Responsible Development	Ministry of the Economy	Responsible for RIS3	info@eco.etat.lu

Regions from across Europe, such as Finland, France, Italy, Portugal, Romania, Sweden, Spain, and the Netherlands, are investing in water-related S3 priorities. These include smart and digital water systems, circular economy practices, sustainable water technologies, and the management of water resources in the context of climate resilience and sustainability. This focus aligns well with Aragón's broad interests in water management, sustainable practices, and innovation in water technologies.

Next the is a detailed analysis of some of the top European water innovation partners, highlighting elements that can be of interest for Aragón and that are considered a good practice for its positive contribution to the positioning of the region and the regional stakeholders in Europe and in European programmes.

Regional cases in detail

North Savo Finland

Region	North Savo Finland		
Region in a nutshell	North Savo is the sixth largest county in Finland in terms of population. Kuopio is a university city with a population of approximately 124,000 students.		
NUTS	3	GDP per capita at current prices (M EUR)	35 381
RIS 2023[6]	122 (Strong Innovator +)	EU RCI 2022[7]	106.8 (Transition region)
S3 priorities	Smart Water System; Machinery/engineering and energy technologies; Forest-based industries; Food; Welfare technologies; Tourism.		
Case identified	**Kuopio Water Cluster a cluster of water expertise and investments from ERDF regional programme.**		
Description	Kuopio Water Cluster is a network of universities, research institutions, and companies dedicated to advancing clean water solutions. Key members include the University of Eastern Finland, Savonia University of Applied Sciences, Geological Survey of Finland, National Institute for Health and Welfare, and Natural Resources Institute Finland.		

[6] Regional Innovation Scoreboard 2023: Score of the NUTS 2 region to which it belongs (Pohjois- ja Itä-Suomi)
[7] Regional Competitiveness 2022: Score of the NUTS 2 region to which it belongs (Pohjois- ja Itä-Suomi)

Region	North Savo Finland		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Water Science Specialties: Digitalisation applied to water, Water microbiology and chemistry, Groundwater and mining water management, Agricultural water impact assessment, Industrial Water treatment, Sludge Valorisation and energy recovery. Technological Innovations: Advanced water purification and monitoring technologies. Smart water technology for risk management and environmental safety. Digital tools for remote monitoring and real-time operations. Industrial Applications: Expertise in mining, industrial, and agricultural water processes. Pilot-scale testing and product development in real industrial sites. Corporate and industrial cooperation. Expertise in product development projects, Industry scale, RDI environment, Start-up centre. National and International Collaboration: Involvement in pilot projects with global partners, enhancing the cluster's internationalization, like Wetsus in Leeuwarden (NL) Collaboration with universities in: Finland, Poland and Sweden concerning innovative industrial wastewater treatment process: Germany, Sweden and Poland in efficient biogas production or sustainable waste management: Finland, Romania, Turkey and France were involved in a project related to smart water networks Main partners include: Finnish Environment Institute (SYKE), University of Oulu, Karelia University of Applied Sciences. South-Eastern Finland University of Applied Sciences, Jyväskylä University of Applied Sciences, Lappeenranta University of Technology, Centre for Measurement and Information Systems (Cemis)		
Additional information	This cluster's focus on sustainable water resource management, innovative treatment methods, and international partnerships makes it an asset for collaboration. Moreover the use of ERDF has made possible to acquire state of the art equipment to carry out applied water industry research and product development. All this combined efforts have made that the operators in the region have profiled themselves within the water sector based on their areas of expertise and, as a whole, Kuopio Science Park is one of Finland's most comprehensive water expertise centres.		
Networks	S3 Thematic Platforms and Partnerships (all): Water Smart Territories Wireless ICT Advanced Materials for Batteries for Electro-mobility and Stationary Energy Storage Other(related to water): Water Cluster Finland (Finnish water industry collaboration) Mining Water Excellence Network of Finland		
Interest for Aragon	Partner for European projects Pilot scales and testing related to product development		
Contact	Name	Position	Email

Region	North Savo Finland		
	Eero Antikainen, MSc (Tech.)	Cluster coordinator	Eero.Antikainen@savonia.fi

Northern Netherlands

Region	Northern Netherlands		
Region in a nutshell	The Northern Netherlands, home to approximately 1.7 million inhabitants across the provinces of Groningen, Friesland, and Drenthe, are a hub of innovation in sustainable solutions. The region excels in clean water and circular economy initiatives, developing cutting-edge technologies for water management and waste reduction.		
NUTS	3	GDP per capita at current prices (M EUR)	63 200
RIS 2023	Groningen: 124.9 (Strong Innovator +) Friesland: 100.3 (Strong Innovator-) Drenthe: 101.6 (Strong Innovator -)	EU RCI 2022	Groningen: 120.2 (More developed region) Friesland: 117 (Transition region) Drenthe: 119.3 (Transition region)
S3 priorities	Renewable energy technologies, agri-food innovations , advanced water management and circular economy technologies, and healthcare solutions		
Case identified	**WaterCampus Leeuwarden: Water technology solutions through an open innovation ecosystem with pivotal linkage to S3**		
Description	WaterCampus Leeuwarden is a leading open innovation ecosystem focused on water technology, located in Friesland, Northern Netherlands. Established in 2003, it has successfully brought together SMEs, research institutes, and end users to tackle water-related challenges both in Europe and globally. The WaterCampus facilitates collaborative business and technological innovation, contributing significantly to the green transition and global water solutions. It is a key player in the Smart Specialisation Strategy (S3) for Northern Netherlands, with a strong focus on water technology's role in climate action, resource efficiency, and sustainability.		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Long-standing track record in water technology and innovation since 2003. Strong collaboration between SMEs, educational institutions, research centres, and public authorities. Active participation in the Entrepreneurial Discovery Process (EDP), enhancing the regional innovation ecosystem. Involvement in global initiatives, including the EU-level "Water Smart Territories" S3 Thematic Platform.		

Region	Northern Netherlands		
	Expertise in tackling both local and global water-related challenges, such as water purification, pollution reduction, and sustainable water use. Access to state-of-the-art research infrastructure, including laboratories and demo-sites for large-scale testing and innovation		
Additional information	WaterCampus operates as an open innovation ecosystem, fostering a continuous Entrepreneurial Discovery Process (EDP). It links education, research, test programmes, and demo-sites, offering a dynamic space for innovation. Its international collaborations include EU cross-border partnerships such as the European Institute of Innovation & Technology (EIT) and the Interreg Europe project iWATERMAP. Moreover, the WaterCampus is an active participant in the "Water Smart Territories" thematic platform, engaging with regions across Europe to address water challenges and develop future investments		
Networks	WaterCampus Leeuwarden network includes over 220 companies and 25 research centres. Key partners include Wetsus (European Centre of Excellence for Sustainable Water Technology), Water Alliance, Centre for Excellence Water Technology (CEW), and BioBizz Hub. Participation in the European Institute of Innovation & Technology (EIT) RawMaterials Innovation Community and the Interreg Europe iWATERMAP project. Engagement in the "Water Smart Territories" S3 Thematic Platform, co-led by Aragon, Centre-Val de Loire, and Friesland, comprising 20 European regions.		
Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem	Extensive experience in European research and innovation projects Large cooperation network with international companies (not based in NL) Recognized PHD careers with relation to water		
Contact	Name	Position	Email
	Pieter de Jong	EU Representative	Pieter.deJong@wetsus.nl

Central Denmark Region (Midtjylland)

Region	Central Denmark Region (Midtjylland)		
Region in a nutshell	Central Denmark Region is one of five regions in Denmark, and it has a population of 1.3 million people - approx. 23% of the population in Denmark. Overall, Denmark excels in water technologies, particularly in water treatment, conservation, and efficient resource management. It is renowned as a top exporter of water technology, significantly advancing environmental and sustainability objectives.		
NUTS	2	GDP per capita at current prices (M EUR)	56 400
RIS 2023	140.7 (Innovation Leader)	EU RCI 2022	119.8 (More developed region)
S3 priorities	(national level)environmental technology, energy technology, food and bio-resources, maritime industries and logistics, life science and welfare technology, building and construction, design, fashion and furniture, advanced production, and digital technologies		
Case identified	**WATEC Aarhus University Centre for Water Technology**		
Description	The Aarhus University Centre for Water Technology (WATEC) is an interdisciplinary research centre established in 2017, focusing on developing sustainable solutions for global water challenges. It integrates expertise from various departments to address issues related to water treatment, conservation, and management		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Advanced Water and Wastewater Treatment: Developing innovative technologies for efficient and cost-effective Constructed Wetland Treatment Technologies: Designing and implementing natural systems for wastewater treatment. Surface Water Management and Restoration: Restoring and managing lakes, streams, and riparian zones to improve water quality and ecosystem health. Water Mapping and Modelling: Utilising advanced techniques to map groundwater resources and model water systems for better management. Sensor Development and Application: Creating advanced sensors for monitoring chemical and biological processes in water treatment.		
Additional information	WATEC collaborates with industry partners and public enterprises to translate research into practical applications, aiming to make Denmark a leading nation in water technology. The centre received a significant donation from the Poul Due Jensen Foundation to boost its activities. In addition, the Water Engineering Innovation (WEI) Lab is an integral part of WATEC. The WEI Lab focuses on developing sustainable physicochemical methods to address challenges in water and energy production, aligning with WATEC's mission to create interdisciplinary solutions for global water issues		

Region	Central Denmark Region (Midtjylland)		
Networks	National Networks: Danish Water and Environment Cluster (CLEAN): WATEC collaborates with CLEAN, a cluster that connects companies, utilities, knowledge institutions, and the public sector to promote market-driven green innovation in Denmark and abroad. Water Valley Denmark: WATEC is part of this alliance, which brings together Danish and international players, including research institutes, startups, and global supply companies, to develop innovative solutions for the water industry.		
Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem	Aarhus University is the third entity in Denmark in Horizon Europe in terms of EU Net contribution (159MEUR) and 290 participation (131 as coordinator)		
Contact	Name	Position	Email
	Uff Sognstrup Thomsen	Special consultant - Department of Biological and Chemical Engineering	ust@bce.au.dk
	Daniel Spelling Clausen	Member of Administrative Staff - Department of Eco science - Arctic Environment	dsc@ecos.au.dk

Networks and good practices

Water Europe

Brief description: Water Europe is a leading European platform dedicated to promoting sustainable water management and fostering a Water-Smart Society. It serves as a hub for collaboration among stakeholders in the water sector.

Geographical scope: Europe-wide, encompassing members from various European countries.

Type of members: Includes a diverse range of stakeholders such as research institutions, private companies, public authorities, and non-governmental organisations involved in the water sector.

Water focus themes: Focuses on water security, sustainability, and resilience, aiming to address challenges related to water scarcity, quality, and infrastructure.

Main activities: Engages in policy advocacy, research and innovation promotion, organisation of events and conferences, and development of strategic programmes to advance water-related initiatives across Europe.

Water Europe Marketplace

Brief description: The Water Europe Marketplace is an online platform designed by Water Europe to connect problem owners, solution providers, investors, and other stakeholders in the circular economy, particularly focusing on water, energy, and materials.

Geographical scope: Primarily Europe, with potential global engagement.

Type of members: Comprises utilities, industries, technology providers, investors, academics, regulatory authorities, NGOs, and other professionals active in the circular economy.

Water focus themes: Emphasises innovative solutions for water reuse, resource recovery, and sustainable water management practices within the circular economy framework.

Main activities: Facilitates networking, business development, knowledge sharing, and exhibition of achievements in water-related circular economy solutions. It also hosts events and supports matchmaking between stakeholders to promote collaboration and innovation.

[Plataforma Tecnologica del Agua (PTA)]

Brief description: The Spanish Water Technology Platform (PTEA) is a collaborative network that aims to promote research, development, and innovation in the Spanish water sector.

Geographical scope: Spain, with a focus on national and regional water challenges.

Type of members: Includes companies, research centres, universities, public administrations, and other entities involved in water management and technology in Spain.

Water focus themes: Concentrates on integrated water resources management, water quality improvement, technological innovation in water treatment, and sustainable water use.

Main activities: Engages in coordinating research and innovation projects, facilitating knowledge exchange, influencing water-related policies, and organising events and workshops to address current and future challenges in the water sector.

[European Circular Economy Stakeholder Platform (ECESP)]

Brief description: The European Circular Economy Stakeholder Platform (ECESP) is a collaborative initiative by the European Commission, serving as a hub for knowledge exchange and stakeholder interaction to drive the transition towards a circular economy in Europe. It acts as a "network of networks," uniting organisations and initiatives that promote circular economy practices across various sectors, including water.

Geographical scope: Europe-wide, encompassing stakeholders from all EU Member States and beyond, aiming to foster collaboration at local, national, and international levels.

Type of members: ECESP includes a wide range of stakeholders such as public authorities, private companies, academia, non-governmental organisations, and citizens' groups active in circular economy initiatives.

Water focus themes: While ECESP addresses broader circular economy themes, it strongly emphasises water-related topics such as:

- Sustainable water management within circular economy frameworks
- Promoting water reuse and recycling
- Technologies for water resource recovery and efficiency
- Reducing water consumption in industrial processes

Main Activities:

- Knowledge sharing: Offers a database of best practices, case studies, and innovative solutions related to circular economy, including water management.
- Stakeholder dialogue: Organises events, conferences, and workshops that foster collaboration on water reuse and sustainability.
- Policy advocacy: Supports the development and implementation of EU circular economy policies, with a focus on integrating water resource management.
- Networking: Provides a platform for stakeholders to connect, collaborate, and exchange ideas on sustainable practices, including those focused on water systems.

Conferences related to water

European Water Technology Week (EWTW) 2024

EWTW is a leading event organised by WaterCampus Leeuwarden that brings together global experts, businesses, and researchers to discuss and showcase innovations in water technology.

It features a dynamic programme with plenary sessions, workshops, and exhibitions, focusing on critical topics like water quality, circular water systems, and sustainable technologies.

The event promotes networking and collaboration, fostering international partnerships and recognising excellence through awards such as the Marcel Mulder Award and the WIS Award.

The recent edition, EWTW 2024, attracted over 1,500 participants from across the globe. The next edition is scheduled for October 5 – 8, 2026.

Centre-Val de Loire

The Centre-Val de Loire region actively engages in water resource management through various conferences and trade fairs. Notable events included:

Regional Water Conference (Assises régionales de l'eau): Held on 7 November 2023 in Tours, this conference was organised by the Centre-Val de Loire region in collaboration

with CESER, water agencies, the DREAM cluster, BRGM, and INRAE. It aimed to initiate dialogue among stakeholders—citizens, associations, professionals, and elected officials—on the future of water resources, addressing challenges posed by climate change and regional droughts.

Cycl'Eau Centre-Val de Loire 2024: Scheduled for 9 and 10 October 2024 at CO'Met in Orléans, this regional trade fair focuses on water management. The fair aims to facilitate meetings between economic and political players, addressing the challenges of water quality and quantity in the Loire-Bretagne Basin, which covers 28% of mainland France. CYCL'EAU is a series of regional trade fairs dedicated to water management in France. It focuses on bringing together public and private stakeholders to address the challenges of water resource management, particularly in the context of climate change, water scarcity, and sustainability

CYCLE'EAU: Other upcoming event.

The CYCL'EAU Montpellier-Occitanie 2025 is scheduled for 19 and 20 March 2025 at the Parc des Expositions de Montpellier. This inaugural event aims to address the region's significant water resource challenges, particularly concerning drought and water scarcity. Montpellier, recognised as a leading French city in water innovation, hosts institutions such as the UNESCO ICIREWARD Centre and the Aqua-Valley competitiveness cluster. The conference will highlight local research excellence, scientific and technological advancements, and best practices in water management. Key partners include the Rhône Méditerranée Corse Water Agency, the Occitanie Region, Montpellier Méditerranée Métropole, BRL, UNESCO, and Aqua-Valley. The detailed programme will be announced in due course.

Additionally, the CYCL'EAU Bordeaux Nouvelle-Aquitaine 2025 is planned for 21 and 22 May 2025 at the Palais 2 l'Atlantique in Bordeaux. Celebrating its sixth edition, this event will convene professionals from the water sector to discuss resource management, showcase innovations, and promote industry stakeholders. The programme includes exhibitions, partner villages, round tables, and workshops, with participation from approximately 150 exhibitors. Notably, this edition will feature AFRICOOP', an initiative dedicated to fostering international cooperation in water management between Africa and Europe.

Venice: Large B-WaterSmart event

This event focused on the future of water management in the Venice region and brought together technicians, scientists, stakeholders, and citizens to promote innovation, collaboration, and sustainable solutions for regional water challenges.

It included a Community of Practice (CoP) session, where stakeholders reviewed initial results from the Venice Living Lab, addressing water reuse strategies and sludge management.

A virtual tour of the pilot plant was organised to demonstrate its role in water purification processes.

During the Water Europe Market Roadshow, technology suppliers and stakeholders explored innovative solutions for circular economy practices and resource recovery.

A citizen engagement workshop highlighted the importance of involving the public in water sustainability decisions, encouraging awareness and informed participation.

ii. Security and Defence

Aragón's industrial ecosystem, led by companies like Instalaza, leverages advanced dual-use technologies and fosters independence from external providers. The good position of the Region in terms of Defense infrastructures and capabilities from the Spanish State and a well stablished network of aeronautics, logistics, and defence clusters set a good scene to promote innovation and collaboration. Strategically located within European transport corridors and supported by renewable energy resources, Aragón is an attractive hub for defence logistics and sustainability.

Aligned with EU priorities to reduce technological dependence and strengthen collaborative research under the European Defence Fund (EDF), Aragón exemplifies the potential of regions driving defence innovation.

Below are other European regions actively contributing to defence and innovation priorities. Data was extracted from the S3 CoP Observatory database and in the cases that this information was not available it was extracted from web search and desk research.

Region name	S3 Priorities	Name	Position	Contact
Croatia	Security and dual use – awareness, prevention, response, resolution	Marija Rajaković;Ana Varjacic	Ministry of Regional Development and EU Funds Ministry of Science and Education	marija.rajakovic@mrrfeu.hr ana.varjacic@mzo.hr
Satakunta	Safety and security of supply	Katja Laitinen	Regional Council of Satakunta	katja.laitinen@satakunta.fi
Denmark	Defence, space and security	Tej Egefjord	Danish Business Authority; Danish Board of Business Development	tejege@erst.dk de@erst.dk deb@erst.dk
Abruzzo	Aerospace	Germano De Sanctis	General Director Abruzzo Region Economic Development Department	+393346230935

Region name	S3 Priorities	Name	Position	Contact
Apulia	Aerospace	Silvia Visciano	Regione Puglia	s.visciano@regione.puglia.it
Ille de France	Aeronautics, space, defense, sustainable and smart mobility	Jean-Bernard Spinat;Louise Pesnel	Conseil Régional d'Ile de France	jean-bernard.spinat@iledefrance.fr louise.pesnel@iledefrance.fr
Nouvelle Aquitaine	Aeronautics, Space and Defence	Bourtembourg Magali	Regional Council of Nouvelle-Aquitaine	magali.bourtembourg@nouvelle-aquitaine.fr
Provence Cote d'azur	Aerospace, security-defense		Région Sud Provence-Alpes-Côte d'Azur	smartdata@maregionsud.fr
Italia	Aerospace and defense		Dipartimento per le politiche di coesione e per il sud	politichecoesioneservizio2@governo.it
Lazio	Security		Direzione regionale Sviluppo Economico, Attività Produttive e Ricerca - Unità organizzativa "Attuazione e Monitoraggio S3"	sviluppoeconomico@pec.regione.lazio.it
Piedmont	Aerospace	Giovanni Amateis	Directorate Competitiveness of Regional System - Research & Innovation Unit	s3@regione.piemonte.it
Malta	Aviation and Aerospace		Ministry for Equality, Research and Innovation with Malta Council for Science and Technology	info.xjenzamalta@gov.mt

The strengths of Aragon defense ecosystem may complement other regions pursuing similar strategic goals, within a broader European network of regions advancing aerospace and defence priorities. France, Italy, and Spain lead these efforts.

Regional cases in detail

Nouvelle-Aquitaine

Region	Nouvelle-Aquitaine		
Region in a nutshell	Nouvelle-Aquitaine is one of France's largest regions, renowned for its relevant economic and innovation performance in the aerospace, defence, and space sectors. The region hosts major aerospace clusters and leading industrial actors, contributing significantly to France's global competitiveness in aeronautics and related industries. It has a well-developed innovation ecosystem in key sectors around aerospace, space exploration, and defence technologies, making it a strategic European hub for innovation-driven growth.		
NUTS	1	GDP per capita at current prices (M EUR)	32661
RIS 2023*	91.99 (Moderate Innovator +)	EU RCI 2022**	
S3 priorities	Aeronautics and space, Advanced manufacturing and materials, Defence and security technologies, Sustainable mobility and energy transition.		
Case identified	**Aerospace Valley Cluster**		
Description	The Aerospace Valley cluster is a leading European competitiveness cluster located in Nouvelle-Aquitaine and Occitanie. It focuses on aerospace, space, and embedded systems, supporting businesses, research institutions, and educational entities in advancing innovation. With over 800 members, including major industry players like Airbus and Dassault, the cluster drives collaborative R&D projects, promotes regional SMEs in European innovation ecosystems, and supports training initiatives to address sector skills needs. It has been instrumental in strengthening the value chain and fostering transformative technologies in aeronautics and defence.		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Industrial leadership: Nouvelle-Aquitaine hosts major players like Airbus, Thales, and Dassault Aviation, positioning it as a European leader in aerospace and defence innovation. R&D excellence: The region excels in collaborative research, driven by institutions like ISAE-ENSMA and Université de Bordeaux, focusing on aerospace materials, digitalisation, and sustainable propulsion systems. SME integration: Strong support for SMEs through the Aerospace Valley cluster, enabling access to funding, technology transfer, and integration into major value chains. Cutting-edge technology focus: Expertise in artificial intelligence for embedded systems, hydrogen propulsion, additive manufacturing, and space-based technologies. Cluster success: Aerospace Valley has delivered over 500 R&D projects, fostering public-private collaboration, skills development, and innovative products in aerospace and defence.		

Region	Nouvelle-Aquitaine		
	Sustainability leadership: The region prioritises sustainable aviation and defence technologies, with projects aiming at carbon-neutral aircraft, energy-efficient systems, and circular economy practices.		
Additional information	The Aerospace Valley cluster has launched over 500 R&D projects and has fostered international partnerships, promoted the export of regional expertise and secured over 2 billion euros in funding for research and development projects, with notable successes including advancements in hydrogen-powered propulsion systems and AI-driven embedded technologies. The cluster plays a vital role in the Horizon Europe programme, fostering innovation networks and promoting cross-border R&D collaborations in aerospace and defence sectors. Key international partnerships have been established with the European Space Agency (ESA) and Clean Sky Joint Undertaking, supporting sustainable aviation goals. Key achievements include advancements in clean propulsion systems, integration of electric aircraft solutions, and collaboration with international space exploration initiatives. The cluster is a member of the Clean Sky programme, contributing to sustainable aerospace innovation in Europe.		
Networks	- Aerospace Valley (European Aerospace Cluster Partnership) - NEREUS (Network of European Regions Using Space Technologies) - Strong ties with the European Defence Fund and Horizon Europe initiatives		
Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem	Nouvelle-Aquitaine offers valuable opportunities for collaboration in aerospace and defence innovation. The Aerospace Valley cluster's experience in fostering innovation partnerships and successful R&D projects can guide Aragón in strengthening its ecosystem. Collaboration can focus on technology transfer, joint participation in European funding programmes, and knowledge exchange in aerospace innovation and defence.		
Contact	Name	Position	Email
	Bourtembourg Magali	Regional Council of Nouvelle-Aquitaine	magali.bourtembourg@nouvelle-aquitaine.fr

Piedmont

Region	Piedmont		
Region in a nutshell	Piedmont is one of Italy's industrial powerhouses, with a strong focus in past years on advanced manufacturing, aerospace, and defence technologies. The aerospace sector in Piedmont excels in developing innovative solutions for propulsion systems, remotely piloted aerial systems, and eco-compatible motor technologies. The region's innovation ecosystem is strongly supported by collaborative networks, logistics and engineering expertise, and integration of SMEs into global value chains.		
NUTS	2	GDP per capita at current prices (M EUR)	32600
RIS 2023*	95.4 (Moderate Innovator +)	EU RCI 2022**	90.1
S3 Priorities	Aerospace & Defense, Mobility, Advanced manufacturing, Food, Health, Technologies, resources, green materials		
Case identified	**Distretto Aerospaziale Piemonte (DAP)**		
Description	The Distretto Aerospaziale Piemonte (DAP) is a regional aerospace cluster that unites industrial leaders, SMEs, research organisations, and institutions to advance innovation in aerospace and defence. It focuses on cutting-edge technologies, including remotely piloted aerial systems, eco-compatible propulsion, electric aircraft, and orbit systems management. The cluster facilitates collaboration across the value chain, enabling Piedmontese aerospace actors to remain competitive in European and global markets. DAP supports R&D, fosters engineering logistics expertise, and promotes innovative platforms for the next generation of air and space systems.		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Advanced propulsion technology: Development of eco-compatible and electric motor solutions, enhancing sustainable aerospace innovation. Remotely piloted aerial systems: Leading expertise in engineering, control systems, and platform integration for unmanned aerial vehicles. Industrial collaboration: Strong partnerships among SMEs, research centres, and large aerospace players to drive technological advancements. Space exploration: Expertise in orbit systems management and space aviation technologies, contributing to Europe's strategic goals for space missions. Engineering logistics: Focus on developing innovative engineering services and logistics platforms to support aerospace systems. Clean aviation: Active participation in European initiatives like Clean Sky, focusing on reducing emissions and enhancing aircraft efficiency.		

Region	Piedmont		
Additional information	The DAP cluster is a key player in the European aerospace ecosystem, with significant contributions to EU-funded programmes like Horizon Europe and Clean Sky. Notable projects include advancements in electric propulsion systems, remotely piloted systems for commercial use, and partnerships in space exploration missions. The cluster integrates SMEs into major aerospace value chains, boosting innovation capacity and international competitiveness. DAP also works closely with European defence programmes to foster dual-use technologies that combine civil and military applications.		
Networks	DAP (Distretto Aerospaziale Piemonte) Clean Sky Joint Undertaking European Defence Fund initiatives European Space Agency collaborations		
Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem	Piedmont's expertise in aerospace and defence innovation aligns closely with Aragón's strategic priorities and could complement Aragon's strengths. Collaboration opportunities include knowledge sharing on logistics. Partnerships could focus on joint R&D projects, technology transfer, and integration of SMEs into European aerospace value chains, leveraging on EU programmes like Horizon Europe and Clean Sky and industry and innovation networks.		
Contact	Name	Position	Email
	Giovanni Amateis	Directorate Competitiveness of Regional System - Research & Innovation Unit	s3@regione.piemonte.it

Region Provence Alpes Cote d'Azur

Region	Provence Alpes Cote d'Azur		
Region in a nutshell	Provence-Alpes-Côte d'Azur (PACA) is a dynamic region in southern France with significant contributions to aerospace, defence, and maritime industries. Home to leading aerospace players such as Thales Alenia Space and Airbus Helicopters, the region is a European hub for innovation in satellite technologies, defence systems, and unmanned vehicles. PACA benefits from strong public-private partnerships, cutting-edge research institutions, and a strategic location near the Mediterranean, fostering trade and innovation. The region also excels in space technologies, propulsion systems, and cybersecurity, positioning it as a key player in European innovation networks.		
NUTS	2	GDP per capita at current prices (M EUR)	32 300
RIS 2023*	103.3 (Strong Innovator -)	EU RCI 2022**	106.7
S3 Priorities	Aerospace, security-defence, Health and silver economy, Nature-based technologies and innovation, Blue economy, Energetic transition, Green transition, Culture, tourism, sport, Key technologies.		
Case identified	**SAFE Cluster**		
Description	The SAFE Cluster in PACA focuses on aerospace, defence, and security technologies. It supports SMEs, large enterprises, and research institutions in developing innovative solutions for air, space, and ground defence systems. Key areas of expertise include satellite technologies, cybersecurity for defence applications, and unmanned aerial vehicles. The cluster promotes collaboration, supports R&D initiatives, and integrates SMEs into global value chains. With over 400 members, SAFE Cluster drives innovation in security and dual-use technologies across Europe		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Satellite and space technologies: Expertise in developing and managing advanced satellite systems and space applications. Cybersecurity leadership: Development of secure communication systems and cybersecurity solutions for defence and civil sectors. Unmanned aerial systems: Innovation in UAV design, engineering, and integration for defence and commercial applications. Advanced propulsion systems: Research and development in eco-compatible and electric propulsion technologies. Maritime and aerospace dual-use technologies: Expertise in technologies that serve both defence and civilian needs.		

Region	Provence Alpes Cote d'Azur		
Additional information	SAFE Cluster is an active participant in European funding programmes like Horizon Europe and EDF. It has established international partnerships with global aerospace leaders and promotes the integration of SMEs into major value chains. Recent achievements include advancements in cybersecurity frameworks for critical infrastructure and collaborations in satellite-based Earth observation projects.		
Networks	SAFE Cluster European Defence Fund initiatives Horizon Europe projects ESA collaborations		
Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem	Aragón's interest in collaborating with PACA stems from shared priorities in cybersecurity, unmanned systems, and dual-use technologies. PACA's SAFE Cluster expertise aligns with Aragón's strengths in advanced logistics, energy-efficient systems, and additive manufacturing.		
Contact	Name	Position	Email
	Not available	Région Sud Provence-Alpes-Côte d'Azur	smartdata@maregionsud.fr

Networks and good practices

Aerospace and Defence Industries Association of Europe (ASD)

Brief description: The Aerospace and Defence Industries Association of Europe (ASD) is a leading trade association representing the aeronautics, space, and defence industries. It focuses on fostering innovation, competitiveness, and collaboration across Europe in aerospace and defence.

Geographical scope: Pan-European, encompassing EU member states and other European nations.

Type of members: Major aerospace and defence companies, SMEs, national trade associations, and research institutions.

Core focus and themes:

- Defence and security innovation
- Aerospace and space technologies
- Sustainability in aviation
- Industrial competitiveness in global markets

Main activities:

- Policy advocacy and industry representation at the EU level.
- Promotion of standards and best practices across aerospace and defence.

- Coordination of collaborative R&D initiatives under EU programmes.
- Facilitating industry networking through conferences and events.

[Clean Aviation Joint Undertaking (Horizon Europe Partnership)]

Brief description: Clean Aviation is a public-private partnership under Horizon Europe dedicated to accelerating innovation for sustainable aviation technologies, focusing on decarbonisation and energy efficiency.

Geographical scope: European Union member states, with international collaborations.

Type of members: Aerospace industries, SMEs, universities, and research organisations.

Core focus and themes:

- Hydrogen and hybrid propulsion systems
- Advanced aerodynamics and lightweight materials
- Energy-efficient aircraft design
- Sustainable aviation fuels

Main activities:

- Funding large-scale R&D projects under Horizon Europe.
- Demonstration of sustainable aviation technologies.
- Facilitating cross-sector collaboration in clean aviation.

[European Aerospace Cluster Partnership (EACP)]

Brief description: EACP is a network of aerospace clusters aimed at fostering innovation, collaboration, and competitiveness among aerospace stakeholders across Europe.

Geographical scope: Primarily EU member states, with international outreach.

Type of members: Aerospace clusters, SMEs, research institutions, and academia.

Core focus and themes:

- Aerospace supply chain optimisation
- Technology transfer and innovation
- Workforce development and skills enhancement

Main activities:

- Organising B2B networking events.
- Supporting internationalisation of aerospace SMEs.
- Coordinating EU-funded projects.
- Facilitating inter-cluster collaborations.

European Network of Defence-Related Regions (ENDR)

Brief description: ENDR connects regions across Europe that are actively involved in defence and dual-use innovation, aligning their activities with the EU's smart specialisation strategies (RIS3).

Geographical scope: EU member states with strong defence-related regional strategies.

Type of members: Regional governments, defence clusters, SMEs, and research centres.

Core focus and themes:

- Dual-use technologies
- Defence innovation ecosystems
- SME integration into European value chains

Main activities:

- Facilitating interregional collaboration on defence innovation.
- Sharing best practices for defence and dual-use technology development.
- Supporting participation in EU funding programmes like EDF.

Conferences related to Security and Defense

Conference "Maintenance in Defence Domains" Trends, Opportunities and Solutions.

1-2 April 2025 - Toulon, France

Co-organised by **DG DEFIS from the European Commission** and **System Factory**

The event will explore innovations and challenges in defence maintenance through panels focusing on:

- Innovation in defence
- International cooperation
- Best practices
- European defence industry collaboration

Key topics include:

- Lessons learned from military operations (e.g., Ukraine)
- Civilian best practices in maintenance management
- Resilience in defence maintenance supply chains
- European defence maintenance standards integration
- Practical applications of AI in maintenance and operator support
- Additive manufacturing in maintenance processes

More info on the event and agenda here

The ENDR Conference on Expanding and Strengthening the European Naval Defence Industry with Non-Traditional Players is scheduled to take place in Cartagena, Spain.

6-7 March 2025 - Cartagena, Spain

This event aims to integrate non-traditional entities into the naval defence sector, fostering innovation and collaboration.

Key Focus Areas:

- Innovation Integration: Exploring how non-traditional players can contribute to advancements in naval defence technologies.
- Collaborative Opportunities: Facilitating partnerships between traditional defence contractors and emerging entities.
- Industry Expansion: Strategies to broaden the European naval defence industry's base by including diverse contributors.

The conference will feature panel discussions, workshops, and networking sessions, providing a platform for stakeholders to exchange insights and establish collaborations.

For more details and registration information, please visit the official event page: ENDR Conference in Cartagena.

iii. Digital with focus on Artificial Intelligence

Below are other European regions actively contributing to Digitalisation in the public sector priorities. Data was extracted from the S3 CoP Observatory database and in the cases that this information was not available it was extracted from web search and desk research.

Region name	S3 Priorities	Name	Position	Contact
Puglia	Advanced mechanics, Electronics, and automation	Silvia Visciano	Regione Puglia	s.visciano@regione.puglia.it
Brussels	Technologies & advanced digital services	No information available	Innoviris	info@innoviris.brussels
Central Finland	Digitalisation	No information available	Regional Council of Central Finland	kirjaamo@keskisuomi.fi

Region name	S3 Priorities	Name	Position	Contact
Kainuu	Digital Transformation	No information available	Regional Council of Kainuu	kirjaamo@kainuunliitto.fi
South Ostrobothnia	Smart Technologies	Pia Kattelus	Regional Council of South Ostrobothnia	kirjaamo@etela-pohjanmaa.fi
Brittany	Secure and responsible digital economy	Aurelie Thomas	Conseil régional de Bretagne - service de l'innovation et des stratégies économiques (SIS)	aurelie.thomas@bretagne.bzh
Mayotte	Tele-technologies	No information available	Agence Nationale de la Cohesion des Territoires	info@anct.gouv.fr
Nouvelle Aquitaine	Digital	Bourtembourg Magali	Regional Council of Nouvelle-Aquitaine	magali.bourtembourg@nouvelle-aquitaine.fr
Pays de la Loire	The emergence and dissemination of advanced production technologies	No information available	Agence Nationale de la Cohesion des Territoires	info@anct.gouv.fr
Baden-Württemberg	Digitalisation, Artificial Intelligence and Industry 4.0	Arndt Oschmann	Ministry of Economic Affairs, Labour and Tourism of Baden-Württemberg	arndt.oschmann@wm.bwl.de;EFRE@wm.bwl.de
Bayern	Digitisation	No information available	Bayerisches Staatsministerium für Wirtschaft, Landesentwicklung und Energie - Referat Grundsatzfragen der Innovations- und Technologiepolitik, Biotechnologie, Medizintechnik	info@stmwi.bayern.de

Region name	S3 Priorities	Name	Position	Contact
Rhineland - Palatinate	Information and communication technology, software systems, artificial intelligence		Ministerium für Wirtschaft, verkeher, landwirtschaft und weinbau	poststelle@mwvlw.rlp.de
Saxony	Digital	Viktor Slavtchev	Saxon State Ministry for Economic Affairs;Labour and Transport	viktor.slavtchev@smwa.sachsen.de; innovationsstrategie@smwa.sachsen.de
Central Macedonia	Digital Technologies	Goulaptsi Maria	Region of Central Macedonia	m.goulaptsi@pkm.gov.gr
Hungary	Public sector innovation	Zoltán Ferenczi	National Research, Development and Innovation Office	s3magyarorszag@nkfih.gov.hu
Ireland	Information and communication technology (ICT) and Information and communication technology (ICT) Services	David Barrett	Department of Enterprise, Trade and Employment; Department of Public Expenditure, NDP Delivery and Reform	david.barrett@enterprise.gov.ie;cpu@per.gov.ie
Aosta Valley	Digitization, Artificial Intelligence, Big Data	No information available	Regione autonoma Valle d'Aosta, Assessorato Sviluppo economico, formazione e lavoro	adg.fesr@regione.vda.it
Autonomous Province of Trento	Information and communication technology and Digital Transformation	Laura Pedron	Autonomous Province of Trento	laura.pedron@provincia.tn.it ; dip.sviluppoeconomico@provincia.tn.it
Emilia-Romagna	Digitalisation, Artificial Intelligence, Big Data (business and PA)	Angelica Laterza	Regione Emilia-Romagna	Angelica.Laterza@regione.emilia-romagna.it
Molise	Innovation in the Information and communication technology system	No information available	Regione Molise; Agenzia regionale per lo sviluppo del Molise	porfesrfse@regione.molise.it vsviluppoitaliamolise@legalmail.it

Region name	S3 Priorities	Name	Position	Contact
Lithuania	Information and communication technology	No information available	Ministry of Economy and Innovation of Lithuania	kanc@eimin.lt
Lubelskie	Digital society	Dominik Majchrowski	Marshal Office of Lubelskie Voivodship	dominik.majchrowski@lubelskie.pl
Silesian	Information and communication technologies	No information available	Marshal's Office of the Silesian Voivodes	ris-jk@slaskie.pl
Norte, Portugal	Technologies, State, Economy, and Society	Paulo Santos;Raquel Meira;Carlos Oliveira	Comissão de Coordenação e Desenvolvimento Regional do Norte	paulo.santos@ccdr-n.pt raquel.meira@ccdr-n.pt carlos.oliveira@ccdr-n.pt
Bucharest	Information and communication technology (ICT)	No information available	Agency for regional development Bucharest Ilfov	contact@adrbi.ro
North-East, Romania	Information and Communications Technology (ICT)	Gabriela Macoveiu	North-East Regional Development Agency	bgris3@adrnordest.ro
Blekinge County, Sweden	Tech - digitalisation and smarter societies	No information available	Region Blekinge	region@regionblekinge.se
North Netherlands	Transition from analog to digital	No information available	Samenwerkingsverband Noord Nederland (SNN)	info@snn.nl

Regional cases in detail

Aosta Valley

Region	Aosta Valley (Valle d'Aosta), Italy		
Region in a nutshell	The Aosta Valley is a small, autonomous region in northwestern Italy, bordered by France and Switzerland. Despite its modest population and area, the region shows a dynamic economic and innovation profile, characterized by strong emphasis on tourism, agriculture, and local craftsmanship. The region's mountainous terrain influences its economic activities and poses challenges for connectivity and service delivery. Aosta Valley has demonstrated commitment to innovation, particularly in leveraging ICT to address geographic challenges, fostering sustainable development, and supporting entrepreneurship in rural and mountainous areas mountainous terrains, making it a haven for nature enthusiasts.		
NUTS	2	GDP at current prices (M EUR)	39 200
RIS 2023*	72.8 (Moderate Innovator -)	EU RCI 2022**	81.3 (More developed region)
S3 priorities	Industry 4.0, Advanced Materials, Energy and Energy Efficiency, Agriculture and the Environment, Circular Economy, Sustainable Mobility, Health, Digitization, Artificial Intelligence, and Big Data, Connectivity, Monitoring of the Environment and the Territory, and Enhancement of Cultural Heritage		
Case identified	**Smart Villages Strategy**		
Description	The Smart Villages Strategy is an innovative initiative led by the Aosta Valley under the framework of the EU strategy for the Alpine region (EUSALP) Action Group. It aims to adapt the smart city concept to rural and mountainous communities in the Alpine region. This strategy promotes the deployment of ICT-based solutions to improve the quality of life, enhance economic opportunities, and ensure sustainable development in these areas. Key activities include fostering entrepreneurship, supporting digital transformation, and encouraging knowledge sharing among local municipalities. The initiative emphasizes leveraging community collaboration to address shared challenges and aims to serve as a model for similar regions across Europe.		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Strong collaboration among rural and mountain communities Focused application of ICT to address geographic and economic challenges Leadership in regional innovation networks, particularly within the Alpine region Promotion of sustainable and inclusive development		
Additional information	The initiative aligns closely with the EU's vision for smart, sustainable, and inclusive growth in rural areas. The Aosta Valley's expertise in integrating ICT in challenging geographic contexts makes it a relevant case for knowledge sharing and collaboration.		
Networks	EUSALP (EU Strategy for the Alpine Region) INTERREG EU Digital Innovation Hubs (DIHs)		

Region	Aosta Valley (Valle d'Aosta), Italy		
Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem	This initiative is relevant to Aragon's innovation ecosystem, particularly its goals in digital transformation and fostering ICT solutions for rural and diverse geographic areas. The model offers insights on leveraging interregional cooperation and best practices for knowledge-sharing networks, enabling Aragon to strengthen its positioning in EU innovation programs. Collaborating with Aosta Valley could also support joint projects and advancements in sustainable rural development.		
Contact	Name	Position	Email
		Regione autonoma Valle d'Aosta, Assessorato Sviluppo economico, formazione e lavoro	adg.fesr@regione.vda.it

Ireland

Country	Ireland		
Region in a nutshell	Ireland is known for its thriving tech sector, the country hosts major global IT companies, bolstered by strong government support for digital transformation and innovation. The public sector actively engages in digital transformation to enhance efficiency and service delivery.		
NUTS	1	GDP at current prices (M EUR)	50 6282.4
EIS 2024	124.5 (Strong Innovator	EU RCI 2022**	N/A
S3 priorities	Advanced Manufacturing and Engineering, Audiovisual/Creative, Marine and Blue Economy, Renewable Energy and Climate Change Mitigation, Agrifood and AgriTech, Information and Communication Technology (ICT) and ICT Services, and Life Sciences, Med Tech, and Medical Devices.		
Case identified	**Foundation Certificate in Artificial Intelligence for Public Servants**		
Description	Launched in 2021 by the Department of Public Expenditure & Reform of Ireland, the Foundation Certificate in Artificial Intelligence is a 12-week training programme designed to enhance the digital skills of Ireland's public servants. The course covers tools, programming, ethics, and project management in AI, equipping participants to drive the digital transformation of the public sector. Funded by local governments, the initiative highlights the importance of building AI competencies within public administration to strengthen digitisation strategies and policies. This programme serves as a model for other regions seeking scalable and transferable AI training solutions for public servants		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Structured AI training tailored to public sector needs Practical focus on tools, ethics, and project implementation Cost-effective and scalable model Support for broader digital transformation initiatives		
Additional information	The programme underscores the critical role of upskilling public servants in leveraging AI for efficient governance. Its success demonstrates the potential for mutualisation among public authorities and integration into comprehensive digital skill-building strategies. It aligns with EU objectives for digital transformation and smart government. More information: https://www.gov.ie/en/campaigns/1cde2-better-public-services/?referrer=/news/Resources/artificial-intelligence-learning-and-development-resources/#		
Networks	Irish Government's Digital Transformation Initiatives European Digital Innovation Hubs (DIHs) Interreg Europe (support for digital capacity building)		

Country	Ireland		
Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem	This initiative aligns with Aragon's focus on fostering digital transformation within its public sector. Insights from Ireland's programme can inform the design of tailored AI training for public servants in Aragon, enhancing local digitisation strategies. The transferable and scalable nature of the initiative makes it a valuable model for boosting digital skills and integrating AI into public administration workflows.		
Contact	Name	Position	Email
	Leah Ryan	European Regions Network for the Application of Communications Technology (ERNACT)	https://www.ernact.eu/

North Middle Sweden

Region	Norra Mellansverige (North Middle Sweden)		
Region in a nutshell	North Middle Sweden comprises the counties of Dalarna, Gävleborg, and Värmland, representing a dynamic and resource-rich region with strong industrial traditions. The area is characterized by a mix of urban centres and rural landscapes, fostering a balance between industrial and natural resource economies. Key industries include forestry, mining, and manufacturing, complemented by emerging strengths in digital technologies and green innovation. With a robust focus on research and development, the region has a thriving innovation ecosystem supported by academic institutions, business clusters, and public sector collaboration. The strategic use of EU funds further accelerates sustainable development and digital transformation in North Middle Sweden.		
NUTS	2	GDP per capita at current prices (M EUR)	32 100
RIS 2024	91.4 (Moderate Innovator +)	EU RCI 2022**	102.8
S3 priorities	S3 Priorities in Gävleborg: Material Technology and Sustainable Production, Bioeconomy, Smart Sustainable Cities and Communities, Sustainable and Inclusive Working Life, and Digital Services and Processes S3 Priorities in Dalarna: Advanced Industry, Innovative Experience Production, Energy-efficient Community Building, and Health and Well-being. S3 Priorities in Värmland: Forest Bioeconomy, Digital Health Innovation, Advanced Manufacturing and Complex Systems, Solar System Solutions, Attractiveness through Sustainable Location Development, Food in Sustainable Interaction, and Computer Games and Gamification		
Case identified	**Service Design/Design Thinking in Public Services, North Middle Sweden**		

Region	Norra Mellansverige (North Middle Sweden)		
Description	The Service Design/Design Thinking initiative in North Middle Sweden focuses on integrating user-centered design methodologies into public service development. By emphasizing empathy, ideation, and prototyping, the initiative enhances the quality and effectiveness of public services. Through collaboration between public authorities, service providers, and citizens, the programme has improved service delivery and strengthened trust in public institutions. The initiative is supported by workshops, training programs, and real-world applications to encourage innovation and address societal challenges effectively.		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Pioneering user-centered approaches in public service design Strong collaboration among public authorities and citizens Integration of design thinking into public administration workflows Enhanced public service quality and accessibility		
Additional information	This initiative highlights the role of innovative methodologies like design thinking in tackling complex societal challenges. Its success demonstrates the potential of participatory approaches in strengthening the public sector's adaptability and responsiveness. The program aligns with EU goals for digitalization, social inclusion, and public service innovation. More information: https://innovationsguiden.se/		
Networks	Swedish Association of Local Authorities and Regions (SALAR) European Innovation Partnership on Smart Cities and Communities (EIP-SCC) Interreg Europe (supporting cross-regional innovation sharing)		
Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem	The design thinking approach provides valuable insights for Aragon's efforts in public service innovation and citizen engagement. By adopting similar methodologies, Aragon can enhance the adaptability, inclusivity, and efficiency of its public services. The initiative's emphasis on collaborative problem-solving and user-focused solutions is particularly relevant to Aragon's digital transformation goals.		
Contact	Name	Position	Email
	Nikoletta Lupó	Project Manager, Gävle Municipality	http://gavle.se

Lithuania

Country	Lithuania		
Region in a nutshell	Lithuania is a rapidly growing innovation hub in the Baltics, leveraging its advanced digital infrastructure and highly skilled workforce. The country has positioned itself as a leader in digital transformation, public-private cooperation, and entrepreneurial growth. Key sectors driving Lithuania's economy include ICT, fintech, and life sciences, supported by government-backed initiatives fostering innovation and startup ecosystems. Lithuania's strategic focus on e-governance and sustainable development ensures the integration of innovative technologies to improve public sector efficiency and societal impact.		
NUTS	1	GDP per capita at current prices (M EUR)	31 500
EIS 2024	92 (Moderate Innovator)	EU RCI 2022**	N/A
S3 priorities	Health technologies and biotechnology, new production processes, materials and technologies and Information and communication technology.		
Case identified	**GovTech Lab**		
Description	GovTech Lab Lithuania serves as a platform to connect public institutions with startups and SMEs to solve public sector challenges through innovation. The initiative follows a structured five-stage process: (1) public institutions present challenges, (2) GovTech Lab assesses the challenges and organizes a competition, (3) startups, SMEs, and entrepreneurs submit proposals, (4) the most promising solution is selected with public sector collaboration, and (5) the chosen entities join the GovTech Incubator programme to develop and refine their solutions. This approach enhances public-private partnerships and accelerates the adoption of innovative services within the public sector.		
Key Strengths and Expertise:	Facilitates collaboration between public institutions and private sector innovators Structured process to identify and address public sector challenges Promotes startup and SME involvement in public service innovation Supports the development of tailored, scalable solutions through the GovTech Incubator The initiative demonstrates how public sector institutions can prioritize challenges, connect with private sector innovators, and develop solutions with social impacts. Additionally, it provides policymakers with a framework to promote institutional innovations by identifying challenges, engaging startups, and monitoring solution outcomes. The incubator framework could be adapted to advance regional innovation goals.		

Country	Lithuania		
Additional information	GovTech Lab exemplifies the potential of public-private partnerships in fostering innovation. By engaging startups and SMEs, the initiative bridges the gap between public sector needs and private sector capabilities, aligning with EU goals for smart, sustainable, and inclusive growth.		
Networks	European GovTech Community Baltic Innovation Network Interreg Europe (support for cross-regional innovation sharing)		
Interest for Aragon innovation ecosystem	GovTech Lab's structured approach to public-private collaboration offers a valuable model for Aragon's innovation ecosystem. Insights from this initiative can inform Aragon's strategies to address public sector challenges, enhance GovTech innovation, and foster digital transformation through partnerships with startups and SMEs. GovTech also facilitates innovation in public procurement by connecting public institutions with private sector solutions. The initiative enables public institutions to identify needs, engage in market consultations, and learn the benefits of innovation while encouraging startups and SMEs to participate in the public procurement process.		
Contact	Name	Position	Email
	Justė Rakštytė-Hoimian	Lithuanian Innovation Centre	j.rakstyte@lic.lt

Networks and good practices

Single Digital Gateway

Brief description: The Single Digital Gateway (SDG) is an EU-wide initiative aimed at providing streamlined access to public administration services for citizens and businesses. The platform offers a unified point of contact for cross-border administrative procedures, ensuring greater transparency and efficiency in accessing public services across the EU. This initiative facilitates seamless interactions between citizens, businesses, and public administrations across Europe, contributing to the broader goal of a digitally cohesive EU.

Geographical scope: The SDG operates across all EU Member States, as well as Iceland, Liechtenstein, and Norway, under the European Economic Area (EEA) agreements.

Type of members: The network involves public administrations at the national, regional, and local levels in participating countries, alongside businesses and citizens as key stakeholders.

Focus and Themes:

- Digital transformation of public administration

- Cross-border service provision
- Accessibility and transparency of public services
- Streamlining administrative processes
- Reducing barriers to mobility within the EU

Main Activities:

- Providing access to information and online administrative procedures through the Your Europe portal.
- Supporting public administrations in digitizing their services and aligning them with EU standards.
- Ensuring compliance with the "Once-Only" principle to reduce redundant administrative burdens.
- Monitoring and assessing the performance and user satisfaction of the gateway.
- Enhancing interoperability of digital systems between EU Member States.

Interopeable Europe

Brief description: The Interoperable Europe network focuses on fostering collaboration and knowledge sharing among public authorities, civil society, and academia to support the digital transformation of public administrations. It offers tools, training, and best practices for developing interoperable and citizen-centric public services across the EU.

Geographical scope: The network spans all EU Member States and includes contributions from civil society and academia across Europe.

Type of members: Members include local and regional public authorities, civil society organizations, academic institutions, and participants from the Interoperable Europe Board.

Focus and themes:

- Interoperability of public digital services
- Citizen-centric digital transformation
- Open and reusable ICT solutions
- E-learning and capacity building for public administration
- Harmonization of national and European interoperability frameworks

Main activities:

- Hosting the Interoperable Europe Academy, which provides e-learning courses and resources on interoperability-related topics, accessible in 24 EU languages.
- Supporting the Joinup Platform, an online space for sharing and learning about e-government solutions and best practices.
- Highlighting good practices, such as Portugal's MOSAICO tool, which ensures a unified citizen experience with digital public services.
- Facilitating working groups under the Interoperable Europe Board to address strategic agenda priorities.

- Providing access to reusable interoperability solutions and innovative use cases to help public administrations align with EU standards

Conferences related to Digitalisation

Factors Influencing AI Adoption by Public Managers (Past event)

27/05/2024, virtual.

This event explores the factors that shape public managers' perceptions of artificial intelligence (AI) adoption in the public sector, based on a survey conducted across seven EU countries. It provides insights into barriers and enablers influencing AI integration in public administration.

Key focus areas:

- Perceptions of AI adoption among public managers
- Barriers and facilitators of AI adoption in the public sector
- Regional and cross-country differences in AI readiness
- Strategies to enhance AI integration in public administration
- Best practices for addressing public sector challenges through AI

More information about the event's highlights here

EU Open Source Policy Summit 2025

31/01/2025, Brussels

The EU Open Source Policy Summit 2025 brings together policymakers, industry leaders, and open-source advocates to discuss the role of open-source software in shaping Europe's digital transformation and innovation landscape. The summit emphasizes the alignment of open-source strategies with EU policies for a sustainable and inclusive digital economy.

Key focus areas:

- Open-source software as a driver for digital transformation
- Policies and frameworks for fostering open-source collaboration
- Sustainability and security in open-source ecosystems
- Open-source contributions to EU digital sovereignty and innovation
- Cross-sectoral partnerships and best practices in open-source adoption

Full agenda is available here

Annex II – Full list of EU partnership and networks

EU Partnerships

Acronym	Partnership Name	Funding Type	Aragón Participants
EP PerMed	European Partnership on Personalised Medicine	Cofinanced	IACS
THCS	European Partnership on Transforming Health and Care Systems	Cofinanced	IACS
Future EP One Health-AMR	Joint action with CSIC (environment) and UNIZAR (animal)	Design Phase	CSIC, UNIZAR
Clean Hydrogen Europe (JU)	Hydrogen Europe	—	DGPII, CIRCE, CSIC, Fundación del Hidrógeno
Innovative Health Initiative	Health Innovation	—	ARAID, IACS
ADRA	Artificial Intelligence, Data and Robotics Partnership	Co-programmed	ITA
euROBOTICS	European Robotics Technology Platform	Co-programmed	ITA
Made in Europe	European Factories of the Future Research Association (EFFRA)	Co-programmed	AITIIP, ITA

EU Networks

	Network / Platform*	Network Description	Domain / Theme	Aragón Participants
1	EIT Urban Mobility	European Institute of Innovation and Technology – Urban Mobility	Mobility	DGPII, ALIA, AERA
2	Water Europe	European Water Technology Platform	Water	DGPII
3	EIT Manufacturing (signature pending)	European Institute of Innovation and Technology – Manufacturing	Manufacturing	DGPII, DGCI
4	Clean Hydrogen Alliance	European Clean Hydrogen Alliance	Energy / Hydrogen	DGPII, Fundación del Hidrógeno de Aragón
5	EARTO	European Association of Research and Technology Organisations	Research and Technology Organisations	CIRCE, AITIIP, ITA
6	EBN	Business and Innovation Centres Network	Innovation Centres	CEEI Aragón
7	AI-MATTERS	Testing and Experimentation Facilities (TEF) for Manufacturing	Advanced Manufacturing	ITA
8	ERIFF	European Regions for Innovation in Agriculture, Food and Forestry	Agriculture / Bioeconomy	CITA
9	EARMA	European Association for Research Managers and Administrators	Research Management	IACS, ARAID, CITA, CSIC, Campus Iberus, IIS Aragón
10	EFSA	European Food Safety Authority	Food Safety	CITA
11	HR Strategy (HRS4R)		Research Excellence	ARAID, IACS, CSIC, Universidad de Zaragoza, IIS Aragón, CIRCE

	Network / Platform*	Network Description	Domain / Theme	Aragón Participants
12	EDIH Aragón	European Digital Innovation Hub Aragón	Digital Innovation	ITA, Universidad de Zaragoza, IAF
13	ALICE	Alliance for Logistics Innovation through Collaboration in Europe	Logistics Innovation	ITA, ALIA
14	NAFEMS	Association for the Engineering Modelling, Analysis and Simulation	Modelling & Simulation	ITA
15	CECE	Committee for European Construction Equipment	Construction Equipment	ITA
16	EMMC	European Materials Modelling Council	Materials Modelling	ITA
17	AMI2030	Advanced Materials 2030 Initiative	Advanced Materials	AITIIP, ITA
18	Hydrogen Europe Research	European Hydrogen Research Platform	Hydrogen	CIRCE, CSIC
19	EERA (Fuel Cell and Hydrogen)		Hydrogen / Energy	CIRCE, CSIC
20	EUREC	European Association of Renewable Energy Research Centres	Renewable Energy	CIRCE
21	EASE	European Association for the Storage of Energy	Energy Storage	CSIC
22	LENS	League of Advanced European Neutron Sources	Neutron Sources	CSIC
23	Nanoscale Horizons Community Board	Nano-related advisory body	Nanoscience	CSIC
24	Nanosafety Cluster	European cluster on nanosafety	Nanotechnology	CSIC

	Network / Platform*	Network Description	Domain / Theme	Aragón Participants
25	EUFRIN	European Fruit Research Institutes Network - Apricot and peach group	Fruit Research	CSIC
26	BGRI	Borlaug Global Rust Initiative	Global Rust (Agriculture)	CSIC
27	Bioenergy		Bioenergy	CSIC
28	EIT Food	European Institute of Innovation and Technology – Food	Agri-food	CSIC
29	EIT Clima	European Institute of Innovation and Technology – Climate	Climate Innovation	CSIC
30	EIT Raw Materials	European Institute of Innovation and Technology – Raw Materials	Raw Materials	CSIC
31	International Institute for Conservation		Cultural Heritage	CSIC
32	CXAFS (IUCr – Crystallography)		Crystallography	CSIC
33	Elettra Synchrotron Review Committee		Synchrotron Science	CSIC
34	ESRF Committee C1		Synchrotron Science	CSIC

* The regional governement participates in all netwroks from nr. 1 to 18

Annex III – List of actions per ecosystem to boost regional ecosystem and international collaborations

The next actions were prioritised by the participant stakeholders in the workshop according to their relevance and expected impact in overcoming the challenges identified.[8]

The selected actions, while designed for implementation in the short term (within the next two years), their effects may unfold over varying time horizons, some will deliver early wins, while others may contribute to deeper systemic change over time.

It is important to note that the feasibility of these actions must be assessed in light of the existing resources and capacities of the regional public administration, as well as the level of political commitment to innovation-driven transformation.

The actions are structured by each of the ecosystems of study and by the role of the public administration to improve internal coordination. They aim to improve internal and external connections and enhance Aragón's positioning in European and international innovation initiatives:

Key actions for the Security and Defence Ecosystem:

Positioning, networking, and lobbying actions

- **Closer engagement with the Ministry of Defence**: Establish close contact with the Ministry of Defence and its Technology Observatory to align Aragón's projects with its needs *(high priority)*
- **Bigger presence in Brussels**: Identify relevant European forums, networks, and platforms with a focus on technology (e.g. STEP platforms) *(high priority)*
- **International presence**: Promote Aragón's potential and products in international markets by participating in sectoral fairs—such as FEINDEF with a regional stand and EUROSATORY within the national pavilion organised by TEDAE—and through stands under the Spain umbrella at relevant events *(high priority)*
- **Increase engagement with the CDTI and its office in Brussels (SOST) as well as with the REPER** (Spain's Permanent Representation to the EU) in Brussels to advance defence topics *(medium priority)*
- **Attract foreign companies and buyers** to discover Aragón's potential *(medium priority)*
- **Engage with leading regions** and actors to enhance positioning (as identified by the CIRCE report) *(medium priority)*
- **Improve positive image of the defence sector**: Strengthen visibility and the positive image of the defence sector *(medium priority)*

[8] The classification of priority actions is based on the level of agreement among participants: actions considered important by more than 51% of participants are classified as high priority; those identified as important by 25% to 50% are classified as medium priority; and those considered important by less than 25% are classified as low priority.

- **Leverage the location** of key military logistics and health units, including the Logistics Academy, with air and land operations (low priority)

Ecosystem dynamization, create spaces for collaboration and exchange

- **Organise events for the ecosystem:** Project presentations, showcasing success stories, networking, inviting foreign companies, attracting consultants, announcing calls, etc. *(high priority)*
- **Mapping exercise:** Develop a knowledge and capacity map of the defence sector and its auxiliary network *(high priority)*
- **Create an expert's group**: Form a group of experts as part of the ecosystem's governance *(high priority)*
- **Collaboration among networks:** Involve hub members in other business associations *(high priority)*
- **Who's Who map**: contact directory *(high priority)*
- **Foster collaboration spaces**: The Innovation Office should facilitate the creation of meeting spaces for the ecosystem *(high priority)*
- **Showcase success stories** to encourage new participation and collaboration (medium priority)

Anticipate and prepare proposals ahead of funding calls

- **Monitoring** of calls and tenders by the Innovation Office *(high priority)*
- Have a **map of actors** interested in participating in calls *(high priority)*
- **EDF (European Defence Fund):** Study of calls and winning companies to develop an approach plan *(high priority)*
- Monitoring of innovation programme **calls supporting dual-use technologies** (e.g., HE clusters 3 & 5) *(high priority)*
- **Training capsules** on how to prepare proposals *(medium priority)*
- Specialised **support to find partners for EDF** (in the style of Horizon Europe) *(medium priority)*
- Contact with system integrators (**market enablers**) to stimulate the transfer of knowledge and technology to market and across sectors *(medium priority)*
- **Foresight** on themes and financing to anticipate opportunities *(medium priority)*
- Accurate and early **access to information** *(medium priority)*

Update of regional support instruments to promote innovation.

- **Promotion of regional calls in collaboration**: Regional research and innovation calls in Security and Defence and dual-use technologies that foster ecosystem collaboration and cohesion *(high priority)*

- **Promote public procurement of innovation** (funding for business research and innovation, national reference to apply for international tenders) *(high priority)*
- Grants to **boost knowledge and transfer** between universities, technology centres, and companies *(high priority)*
- **Explore tailored support programmes**: Three-year joint programmes for key enterprises aligned with defence needs *(high priority)*
- Include **regulatory frameworks for dual-use technologies** or remove them when they pose a restriction *(medium priority)*
- **Support for late-stage development in technology projects** alongside the validating and integrating ecosystem *(medium priority)*
- **Grants for strategic projects**: transport, logistics *(medium priority)*
- Grants for Innovative Business Groups in Defence (robotics, 5G...) with **topics directed to defence** *(medium priority)*
- **Promotion of entrepreneurship** in the field of Defence, Security, and dual-use technologies *(medium priority)*

Training

- **Training in sector-specific regulations** and on accreditation and certification to enter the sector *(high priority)*
- **New degrees in Security and Defence**: bachelor's in defence engineering, specific master's, targeted subjects *(high priority)*
- Strengthen military training and experimentation centres that are currently not connected *(high priority)*
- **Focus of research**: Support for mature research groups considering new research lines, PhDs and industrial doctorates *(high priority)*
- **Retraining military professional**: Opportunities for retraining military professionals in innovation and public-private collaboration projects *(medium priority)*
- **Defence culture** training in universities *(medium priority)*
- Specific **training** capsules *(medium priority)*

Technological infrastructures

- **Testing & validation**: Create a dedicated laboratory for the functional validation of defence systems *(high priority)*
- **Sector support facilities**: Implement technological infrastructures and laboratories to serve the defence and dual-use sector *(high priority)*
- **Innovation district**: Leverage the Aragonese Technology District (DAT Alierta) to create a dual-use technology innovation centre *(high priority)*

- **Multi-purpose infrastructure**: Enhance innovation infrastructures by leveraging transport infrastructures for other uses, such as energy and telecommunications *(medium priority)*
- **Cross-border connectivity**: Improve railway connection with France *(medium priority)*
- **Air logistics**: Strengthen and improve the logistics capabilities of Zaragoza airport due to its dual civil-military use *(medium priority)*
- **Cybersecurity readiness**: Strengthen cybersecurity infrastructures *(medium priority)*
- **Strategic alignment**: Include the Defence Hub in the strategic logistics plan *(medium priority)*
- **Advanced logistics operations**: Provide secure storage capacity and advanced stock management within the hub *(medium priority)*

Key technologies for specialisation

- Guided drones, navigation and control *(high priority)*
- RPAS drones *(high priority)*
- Military 5G and 6G *(high priority)*
- Aerospace *(high priority)*
- Stratosphere exploitation *(medium priority)*
- Digital technologies: Cognitive systems *(medium priority)*
- Operational logistics *(medium priority)*
- Low altitude geointelligence *(medium priority)*
- Psy-ops: communication of defence messages. Development of Spanish technology and European coordination *(medium priority)*
- Active protection *(low priority)*

Priority Areas for the Innovation Office's Short-Term Roadmap

- Positioning actions (international, Brussels, Ministry of Defence) *(high priority)*
- Dynamization of the ecosystem, create spaces for collaboration and exchange *(high priority)*
- Update regional support instruments to promote innovation *(high priority)*
- Proactively prepare proposals for funding calls *(medium priority)*
- Reinforce training actions *(medium priority)*
- Support for technological infrastructures *(medium priority)*

Key actions for the Water Ecosystem

Participants prioritized a consolidated list of actions aimed at strengthening the regional ecosystem and improving its positioning, with the following results:

Positioning and networking

- **Strategic niches in water security**: Identify areas of opportunity at the intersection of economic security and water technologies to drive innovation and investment. *(high priority)*
- **Water in industrial policy**: Integrate water as a core strategic element in Aragón's industrial planning and policy frameworks. *(high priority)*
- **Strengthen European partnerships**: Reinforce Aragón's role in EU-level water innovation initiatives through S3 and collaboration with Water Europe and Water4All. *(medium priority)*
- **Specialise in water footprint**: Advance regional expertise and capabilities in measuring and reducing water footprints in various sectors. *(medium priority)*
- **Grow regional companies**. Support the expansion and competitiveness of Aragón-based enterprises in the water and innovation ecosystem. (low priority)

Instruments

- **Data-driven water management tools**. Advance the development of digital tools and platforms for more effective, evidence-based water governance. *(high priority)*
- **Regional use case for HAPS**: Develop a regional application of High Altitude Pseudo-Satellites to support water monitoring and related technologies. *(high priority)*
- **Mission-driven innovation**: Support innovation lines that align with defined societal and environmental missions, especially related to water challenges. *(high priority)*
- **Pilot and collaborative projects**: Launch experimental and cross-sector initiatives with public-private participation to test scalable solutions. *(medium priority)*
- **PPI project identification**. Identify suitable Public Procurement of Innovation (PPI) opportunities and funding channels like CDTI. *(medium priority)*

Strategy

- **Strategic assessment of Aragón's water sector and economic resilience**: Evaluate the region-s water cycle, climate vulnerability, and economic development to guide future planning amid global and sectorial pressures. *(high priority)*
- **Regional Water and climate change adaptation strategies**: Climate change adaptation plan with adjustment of water supply to future demands *(high priority)*
- **Competitiveness and strategic alignment**: Conduct analysis based on the Competitiveness Compass and align priorities with EU and commissioner agendas. *(high priority)*
- **Entrepreneurship with impact**. Encourage the creation of new businesses aimed at solving water-related challenges and societal needs. *(medium priority)*

- **Applied research promotion**. Support the development of practical research applications, particularly in sensors and real-time monitoring technologies. *(medium priority)*

Mapping of opportunities

- **Mapping collaboration networks** Identify key stakeholders and good practices to strengthen ecosystem coordination and cross-sector collaboration. *(high priority)*

Capacity-Building and Ecosystem Development

- **Promote a water culture**: Raise awareness among stakeholders and attract investment by building a shared vision around water sustainability. *(high priority)*
- **Knowledge transfer on emerging pollutants**. Facilitate the uptake of research by companies to address new and evolving water contaminants. *(medium priority*
- **Water management training.** Provide targeted training for companies and local entities to enhance water governance and technical skills. *(medium priority)*

Key actions in the digitalisation in the public sector with focus on AI

Actions aimed at strengthening the regional ecosystem and improving its positioning:

Strategy

- **AI strategy with resources**: Relaunch a well-resourced AI strategy to align efforts and scale up innovation impact across the ecosystem. *(high priority)*
- **Aragón AI Agency (public-private initiative)**: Establish a dedicated agency to lead, coordinate, and amplify AI efforts across sectors. *(high priority)*

Policy instruments

- **Adapt policy instruments**: Update and new regional instruments (calls) to boost ecosystem collaboration. Revise and expand funding mechanisms and collaboration incentives. *(high priority)*
- **Pilot-based innovation**: Promote pilot contracts (new in administration) to generate networks: Launch pilot initiatives to test, learn, and foster partnerships. *(high priority)*
- **Proposal support**: Support to prepare European proposals. Assist regional actors in preparing strong applications for EU funding programmes. *(medium priority)*
- **Strategic evaluation capacity.** Technical assistance/expert group to pre-evaluate strategic AI proposals for administration. Ensure quality and coherence in AI public initiatives. *(medium priority)*
- **Market-driven innovation**: Promote public procurement of innovative solutions to stimulate market opportunities. *(medium priority)*

- **Structured collaboration model with instruments**: Use Coordination and Support Actions (CSA) to build lasting networks and collaborative ecosystems. *(medium priority)*

Mapping of actors and opportunities

- **Mapping of actors, capabilities, experts, and success cases**: Identify and showcase key players and assets to strengthen coordination and visibility. *(high priority)*
- **Active guidance for calls** (e.g., AEI ERC-style sessions): Offer structured support to improve success in competitive funding calls. *(medium priority)*
- **Dialogue and responsiveness**: Promote a market communication channel with the administration (proactive). Create a structured, two-way channel to align public policy with industry needs. *(medium priority)*

International positioning

- **International visibility**: Positioning Aragón (brand, participation in European networks). Promote Aragón's AI capabilities through EU networks and strategic branding. *(high priority)*
- **International partnerships.** Connect companies with Brussels. Facilitate connections between Aragón-based companies and EU-level institutions. *(medium priority)*

Training

- **Training on AI use** (administration, business, education): Build human capital by delivering targeted AI training to key stakeholder groups. *(high priority)*

In the view to have a refined overall picture of the priority areas in this ecosystem, the actions above were grouped and prioritized:

- Relaunch AI Strategy with resources *(high priority)*
- Mapping of actors, capabilities, experts, and success stories *(high priority)*
- Update and new regional instruments to strengthen ecosystem collaboration (grants, public procurement, working groups, forums) *(high priority)*
- Positioning Aragón (brand, participation in EU networks) *(high priority)*
- Use case identification *(medium priority)*
- Support for preparing European proposals *(medium priority)*
- AI usage training *(medium priority)*
- Active advisory services (e.g. AEI ERC-style sessions) *(medium priority)*

The fact that some of the actions were identified as less priorities (i.e. medium priority) does not mean they are not important, as they can be already being implemented and contributing positively to the ecosystem e.g. use case identification. The prioritisation is seen as actions to improve positioning on top of what is being done.

Key actions for the Regional Government

All the following actions were seen as of high priority:

Policy and instruments

- **Coordination of calls**: Align Aragón's strengths with national and international strategic calls (FID, Innovation Ecosystems, etc.)
- **Mainstream Innovation**: Define R&I strategies by each main department of the regional government
- **S3 reinforcement**: Update the S3 strategy and improve its monitoring system
- **Information repository**: Information processing system on new EU strategies
- **Financial foresight** to identify trends and opportunities
- **Identify niches of opportunity** for specialisation opportunities

Mapping of opportunities

- **European benchmarking**: Benchmark best practices from European regions to inspire policy improvement, strategic alignment, and enhance regional competitiveness through shared learning experiences.
- **Centralised guidance hub**: Position the Innovation Office as a centralised hub for navigating programmes, tools, and opportunities, making information accessible and boosting user engagement.
- **Access to funding tools**: Ensure the Innovation Office provides practical information and access to funding instruments for stakeholders, with clear guidance tailored to their specific needs.
- **Project opportunity platform**: Use a platform for European and national projects to share open calls, upcoming deadlines, and collaboration opportunities in a timely and structured way.
- **Knowledge repository**: Create a shared knowledge hub with reusable documents and materials to streamline future projects, improve transparency, and foster institutional memory across organisations.

Training

- **Project-focused training**: Deliver specific training on European projects to build the region's capacity for participation, proposal development, and effective project coordination over time.
- **Capacity building in administration**: Address skill gaps in public administration through targeted training on innovation, funding tools, and administrative procedures to enhance internal capabilities.

Consolidate the ecosystem

- **Stronger coordination networks**: Strengthen coordination among networks (e.g., idi, environmental entities) to foster a cohesive ecosystem and avoid duplication of efforts or fragmentation.
- **Cross-sector knowledge exchange**: Use the Innovation Office to facilitate cross-sectoral knowledge-sharing and dialogue, promoting mutual understanding and collaborative problem-solving approaches.
- **Forums for visibility and learning**: Host high-level forums to build awareness and capacity on EU aid and collaborative projects, while showcasing local strengths to national and international partners.
- **International representation**: Promote Aragón's innovation ecosystem at international fairs, including diverse actors like clusters, SMEs, and research institutions for broad and inclusive representation.
- **Ongoing working group efforts**: Maintain momentum by continuing GT working groups focused on networks and platforms, ensuring regular meetings, clear agendas, and shared follow-up actions.
- **Regional branding in R&I**: Reinforce Aragón's brand as a regional leader in research and innovation through strategic communication, visibility campaigns, and presence in European forums.

Reforms

- **Staff stability and growth**: Ensure personnel continuity and capability by stabilising and developing capacities of staff in innovation roles, offering incentives, and reducing staff turnover as main outcome.
- **Professional EU funds manager**: Build specialised fund management capacity with dedicated professional profiles, capable of writing proposals, understanding EU programmes and EU financial regulations and reporting requirements.

Dedicated EU coordination role: Create a specialised role in the administration to coordinate EU funding strategies, foster alignment across departments, and maximise project impact and outreach.

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